A DOCTORAL THESIS

THE Gilded Seam

Paranoia, Reparation, and the Metaphysics of Mending in the Fiction of Philip K. Dick



MMXXVI

The time is out of joint. O cursed spite, / That ever I was born to set it right!

William Shakespeare, *Hamlet* (c. 1600), I.v



Die Wunden des Geistes heilen, ohne daß Narben bleiben.

The wounds of Spirit heal, and leave no scars behind.

G. W. F. Hegel, *Phänomenologie des Geistes* (1807), "Der Geist," C.c



Die Wunde schließt der Speer nur, der sie schlug.

The wound is closed only by the spear that struck it.

Richard Wagner, *Parsifal* (1882), Act III

Abstract

For half a century the criticism of Philip K. Dick (1928–1982) has been organised around a single figure: the counterfeit world, and the paranoid subject who detects it. Ideology-critique (Suvin, Jameson, Fitting, Freedman) read Dick's collapsing realities as allegories of commodity reification; postmodern theory (Baudrillard, McHale, Hayles, Palmer, Rossi) canonised him as the novelist of the simulacrum and of the ontological dominant; theological scholarship (Galbreath, Sutin, Mckee, Davis, Kripal) recovered him as a Gnostic visionary for whom the cosmos is a prison to be seen through. These traditions disagree about nearly everything except the structure of the reading they perform. Each is a hermeneutics of suspicion, and each reenacts at the level of method the very paranoia it identifies as Dick's theme.

This dissertation argues that the consensus mistakes Dick's engine for his destination. Drawing on Melanie Klein's distinction between the paranoid-schizoid and depressive positions, and on Eve Kosofsky Sedgwick's opposition of paranoid to reparative reading, it demonstrates that Dick's novels repeatedly traverse, within individual texts and across the arc of the oeuvre, a passage from splitting (real and fake, human and android, true God and demiurge) and persecutory anxiety toward integration, mourning, and repair. Their decisive climaxes are not revelations but acts of care directed at degraded, counterfeit, or broken things: an electric toad supplied with electric flies, a stranger embraced at an all-night gas station, a blue flower hidden in a shoe as a gift for friends, a crude vessel thrown by a man who has spent his life mending the vessels of others.

Five genealogies are reconstructed to account for this structure: the Heraclitean distinction between the *idios kosmos* and the *koinos kosmos*, transmitted to Dick through Ludwig Binswanger's existential psychiatry; Gnostic, Lurianic, and Origenist narratives of cosmic fracture and restitution; thermodynamic and information-theoretic accounts of entropy and negentropy; the Marxian, Benjaminian, and Baudrillardian critique of the commodity and the simulacrum; and the psychoanalytic theory of paranoia from Freud's Schreber case through Lacan to Klein. Throughout, Dick's work is set against cognate projects in speculative and philosophical fiction, among them those of Stanisław Lem, Ursula K. Le Guin, Thomas Pynchon, Jorge Luis Borges, Arkady and Boris Strugatsky, Octavia E. Butler, Kazuo Ishiguro, Ted Chiang, and Peter Watts.

The original contribution of the study is a theory of *reparative ontology*, figured through the Japanese practice of kintsugi as *the gilded seam*. Against naïve realism (the real is given), against Baudrillardian hyperreality (the real is lost), and against Gnostic dualism (the real is elsewhere), reparative ontology holds that the real is *mended*: an entity's ontological standing is a function of the history of care it has received and the relations of maintenance it sustains, and the site of repair, far from being effaced, becomes the locus of value. Dick named two questions as the abiding subjects of his work, namely what reality is and what constitutes the authentic human being. This study shows that the fiction subordinates both to a third: *what is worth repairing?* The argument is distilled into twelve propositions, a *Tractatus Reparativus*, and extended to three fields in which Dick's questions have ceased to be speculative: the metaphysics of simulation, the ethics of machine minds, and the ecology of a damaged planet.

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Texts and Abbreviations



Dick's fiction circulates in dozens of editions, so references are to the work, and where useful to its episode, rather than to pagination. Dates are of first book publication; composition dates are noted where they diverge materially. Essays and speeches are cited by title and year from *The Shifting Realities of Philip K. Dick* (SR). Dick's arguments are paraphrased throughout; quotation from his work is confined to his coinages. Translations from Greek, Latin, German, and French are the author's.

ABBREVIATION	WORK	FIRST PUBLISHED
EIS	*Eye in the Sky*	1957
CP	*The Cosmic Puppets*	1957
TOJ	*Time Out of Joint*	1959
MHC	*The Man in the High Castle*	1962
MTS	*Martian Time-Slip*	1964
SIM	*The Simulacra*	1964
PT	*The Penultimate Truth*	1964
CAM	*Clans of the Alphane Moon*	1964
3SPE	*The Three Stigmata of Palmer Eldritch*	1965
DB	*Dr. Bloodmoney, or How We Got Along After the Bomb*	1965
NWLY	*Now Wait for Last Year*	1966
CCW	*Counter-Clock World*	1967

ABBREVIATION	WORK	FIRST PUBLISHED
DADES	*Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?*	1968
U	*Ubik*	1969
GPH	*Galactic Pot-Healer*	1969
MD	*A Maze of Death*	1970
WCBY	*We Can Build You* (written 1962)	1972
FMT	*Flow My Tears, the Policeman Said*	1974
ASD	*A Scanner Darkly*	1977
VALIS	*VALIS*	1981
DI	*The Divine Invasion*	1981
TTA	*The Transmigration of Timothy Archer*	1982
RFA	*Radio Free Albemuth* (written 1976)	1985
SR	*The Shifting Realities of Philip K. Dick*, ed. Sutin	1995
EX	*The Exegesis of Philip K. Dick*, ed. Jackson and Lethem (written 1974–82)	2011

The Third Question

0.1 *A Dog's Theology of Garbage*

Dick's first sale to a science-fiction magazine, "Roog" (sold 1951, published 1953), is focalised through the cosmology of a dog. Boris watches his family deposit carefully wrapped offerings in a metal urn each week, and watches with mounting terror as uniformed creatures he calls Roogs arrive to carry the offerings away; the humans' indifference to this recurring sacrilege is, for the dog, the horror of the story. Dick later glossed the premise with disarming literalism: the animal reasons that whatever the family stores so carefully must be what it most values, and so concludes that the garbage collectors are thieves. The story is slight, but its structure is prophetic. From the outset Dick's metaphysics is a metaphysics of refuse. The question of what is precious and what is waste, of what is sacred and what is garbage, is posed at the curb, and it is posed by a creature whose *Umwelt*, in Jakob von Uexküll's sense, is incommensurable with the world of the humans it loves and guards.

Nearly three decades later, in a 1978 speech posthumously published as "How to Build a Universe That Doesn't Fall Apart Two Days Later," Dick proposed that the symbols of the divine enter our world first at its lowest level, which he named the *trash stratum*. Between the dog's urn and that stratum lie some forty-four novels, more than a hundred and twenty stories, and the roughly eight thousand manuscript pages of the *Exegesis*, the private theological commentary Dick composed from 1974 until his death. The arc these texts describe is conventionally narrated as a descent into, or an ascent through, paranoia: the progressive discovery that the world is fake. This dissertation argues that the arc runs otherwise. The dog's error is not that it mistakes garbage for treasure. Its insight, which no human in the story shares, is that the discarded is where value is decided.

0.2 *Three Waves of Suspicion*

In the same 1978 speech Dick identified the two topics that had absorbed him throughout his career: the nature of reality and the constitution of the authentic human being. The critical literature has arranged itself around these questions in three overlapping waves, each of which has produced indispensable readings, and each of which shares, beneath its specific commitments, a common hermeneutic posture.

The first wave, ideology-critique, crystallised in the March 1975 special issue of *Science Fiction Studies* devoted to Dick, which printed Darko Suvin's "P. K. Dick's Opus: Artifice as Refuge and World View," Fredric Jameson's "After Armageddon: Character Systems in *Dr. Bloodmoney*," and Stanisław Lem's "Philip K. Dick: A Visionary Among the Charlatans." For Suvin, Dick's unstable worlds registered the alienations of a late-capitalist order in which artifice functions at once as refuge from social reality and as figure for it. Jameson treated the novels as laboratories of reification and collective praxis, their character systems as maps of social contradiction, a line of argument he extended across three decades (Jameson 1991; 2005). Peter Fitting (1983) read the reality breakdowns as the exposure of reality itself as ideological construct. Carl Freedman (1984) argued that paranoia is the privileged cognitive mode of Dick's social criticism, and that science fiction and paranoia are structurally homologous, since both totalise, both construct systems, and both presume that nothing is accidental. Scott Durham (1988) traced a movement from the death of the subject to a theology of late capitalism. Lem, the wave's dissenter, admired the visionary force of Dick's conceptions while deploring the pulp machinery in which they were delivered.

The second wave, postmodern and ontological, arrived with Jean Baudrillard's *Simulacres et simulation* (1981), which placed Dick beside J. G. Ballard in a third order of simulacra where the distinction between the real and the imaginary no longer obtains (see also Baudrillard 1991). Brian McHale (1987) made science fiction the ontological genre par excellence and Dick an exemplary witness to the shift from the epistemological dominant of modernism, which asks how the world can be known, to the ontological dominant of postmodernism, which asks which world this is. N. Katherine Hayles (1999) read the mid-sixties novels as boundary work at the junction of cybernetics, gender, and schizoid affect; Christopher Palmer (2003) as an oscillation between the exhilaration and the terror of the postmodern; Umberto Rossi (2011) as a corpus of ontologically uncertain narratives. Jameson's

reading of *Time Out of Joint* as the 1950s' representation of itself became a set piece of the theory of postmodernism (Jameson 1991), and his description of Dick as the Shakespeare of science fiction has hardened into a commonplace.

The third wave, theological and esoteric, followed the visionary experiences of February and March 1974 and their fictionalisation in *VALIS* (1981). Robert Galbreath (1982) diagnosed an ironic Gnosticism. Lawrence Sutin's biography (1989) and his selection from the *Exegesis* (1991) made the theological Dick available to scholarship. Gabriel Mckee (2004), Erik Davis (1998; 2019), and Jeffrey J. Kripal (2011) situated Dick within the histories of science-fictional religion, technognosis, and the paranormal, and Pamela Jackson and Jonathan Lethem's edition of the *Exegesis* (2011) opened the primary record to general scrutiny.

These waves differ in almost every substantive respect, yet they share a structure. Each is a hermeneutics of suspicion in Paul Ricoeur's sense (1965): the manifest world is treated as a mask, and the critical task as unmasking, whether by class analysis, by the semiotics of the simulacrum, or by gnosis. Each is, in the vocabulary Sedgwick (2003) borrows from Silvan Tomkins, a strong theory: anticipatory, totalising, and faithful to the efficacy of exposure. Freedman's homology between science fiction and paranoia is in this respect also a self-description of criticism. The critic becomes the paranoid reader that Dick's plots solicit, and the plots' revelations are reenacted as method. Popular culture has amplified the posture. The adaptations and their progeny render Dick as an author of twists, and the cinematic pill that separates the deceived from the awakened has been adopted, from around 2010, by men's-rights forums and the online far right as a figure of awakening to supposed hidden truths about women, race, and politics, the Gnostic plot surviving there stripped of any ethical supplement. Bruno Latour's warning (2004) that critique's debunking gesture had become indistinguishable from the conspiracy theorist's applies with special force to a corpus that has been read, almost without exception, as a manual of suspicion.

0.3 *The Argument: From Paranoia to Reparation*

The paranoid consensus is not wrong about Dick's materials. It is wrong about their direction. Klein distinguished two fundamental positions of psychic life (Klein 1935; 1946). In the paranoid-schizoid position the object is split into an idealised good and a persecutory bad; anxiety is persecutory; defences are omnipotent; the characteristic phantasies are oral, of devouring and being devoured. In the

depressive position the subject apprehends the object as whole, recognises that the loved and the hated are one, suffers guilt and concern for the damage it has imagined inflicting, and turns toward *reparation*. Klein insisted that these are positions rather than stages: psychic life oscillates between them throughout its course. Sedgwick translated the distinction into a theory of reading, opposing the paranoid critic's faith in exposure to a reparative practice that, having passed through suspicion, seeks to assemble and sustain its object rather than to demystify it.

This dissertation argues that Dick's fiction enacts, repeatedly and with increasing deliberateness, the passage from the first position to the second. Its materials are paranoid-schizoid: counterfeit worlds, persecutory demiurges, the split between human and android, the dualism of a rational and an irrational god, and a striking density of oral persecution, from Palmer Eldritch's steel teeth to the devouring Jory of *Ubik*. Its climaxes are reparative. Tagomi, returned from a world not his own, refuses to sign the order that would deliver a Jewish craftsman to the German consulate (MHC). Deckard's wife orders artificial flies for an artificial toad (DADES). A police general who has lost everything embraces a stranger at an all-night gas station (FMT). An organ-transplant surgeon chooses to remain with a wife whom a drug has damaged beyond cure (NWLY). A brain-damaged narcotics agent hides a blue flower in his shoe as a Thanksgiving gift for his friends (ASD). A pot-healer who has spent his life mending the vessels of others throws, badly, a vessel of his own (GPH). The novels do not end in the disclosure that the world is fake. They end when someone decides what, in a damaged and partly counterfeit world, is to be cared for.

I name the position these climaxes articulate *reparative ontology*. Its governing figure is taken from kintsugi, the Japanese practice of mending broken ceramics with lacquer dusted or mixed with gold, so that the history of breakage becomes the most visible and valued feature of the repaired object. Reparative ontology holds that the real is neither given, as naïve realism assumes, nor lost, as Baudrillard's hyperreality proclaims, nor elsewhere, as Gnostic dualism teaches, but *mended*; that an entity's ontological standing is a function of the care it has received and the relations of maintenance it sustains; and that the seam, the site where the counterfeit meets the restored, is the locus of value rather than a flaw to be concealed. Dick famously offered an operational definition of reality as whatever persists once one stops believing in it. The fiction supplies a clause the definition omits: what persists after belief is withdrawn persists because care has not been.

Hence the third question that Dick's two questions presuppose and that his novels answer by action rather than assertion: *what is worth repairing?* The answer, with remarkable consistency, is what the world has discarded. I call the principle governing that answer the *kenotic gradient*, after the self-emptying (*kenōsis*) of Philippians 2:7. In Dick's cosmos, ontological and sacral value vary inversely with exchange value, so that grace pools where the market has abandoned things.

0.4 *Method: Reparative Reading, Genealogy, Comparison*

The study proceeds by four methods. The first is reparative reading, which is not naïve reading. It accepts that Dick's worlds are counterfeit, that his institutions are persecutory, and that his god may be insane; it declines only to treat the demonstration of these facts as the end of interpretation.

The second is genealogy. Because the thesis concerns the originators of the ideas Dick absorbed, it distinguishes three relations between Dick and the thinkers it invokes. *Documented influence* designates sources Dick demonstrably read or cited: the existential psychiatry of Ludwig Binswanger and Eugène Minkowski in the anthology *Existence* (May, Angel, and Ellenberger 1958); the Wilhelm–Baynes translation of the *I Ching* (1950) with C. G. Jung's foreword; the *Encyclopedia of Philosophy* edited by Paul Edwards (1967), a principal quarry of the *Exegesis*; *The Nag Hammadi Library in English* (Robinson 1977); Hans Jonas on Gnosticism; Julian Jaynes on the bicameral mind; split-brain neuroscience; Wagner, Dowland, Goethe, and the Book of Acts. *Structural affinity* designates thinkers whose concepts illuminate Dick without evidence of direct transmission: Berkeley, Leibniz, Heidegger, Isaac Luria, Klein. *Anticipation* designates later thought that Dick's fiction prefigures: Baudrillard, Bostrom, Chalmers, and contemporary debates about artificial minds. Claims are marked accordingly throughout.

The third method is close reading of some twenty-five novels, a selection of stories, the principal essays and speeches, and the *Exegesis*. The fourth is comparison with cognate works of speculative and philosophical fiction, undertaken not to rank Dick but to locate the specificity of his solutions to problems his contemporaries and successors share.

A word on psychobiography. Dick was born six weeks premature on 16 December 1928 with a twin sister, Jane, who died on 26 January 1929; the infants had been inadequately fed, and Dick's lifelong grievance against his mother, together with his conviction that he was a surviving half, is richly documented

(Sutin 1989). Jane's headstone in Fort Morgan, Colorado, carried her brother's name as well as her own; his ashes were interred beside her in 1982, beneath a stone that had awaited his death date for fifty-three years. Klein's theory, with its insistence on the phantasies of the starving and devouring infant, is used here as a heuristic for reading structures in texts, not as a diagnosis of their author. Where the life is invoked it is read as another text, one whose recurrent figures (the lost twin, the dark-haired girl, the failed feeding) the fiction elaborates, rather than as the cause of which the fiction is an effect.

The study acknowledges a precedent. Kim Stanley Robinson's *The Novels of Philip K. Dick* (1984), an early doctoral dissertation on Dick written under Jameson's supervision at the University of California, San Diego, belongs to the first wave. The present work seeks to complete the circle Robinson's opened, by showing that the dialectical energies Jameson located in Dick's character systems resolve not into totality but into repair.

0.5 *Architecture and Claims to Originality*

Part One reconstructs the genealogies of the unreal. Chapter 1 traces the Heraclitean distinction between private and common worlds from the Presocratics through Binswanger to *Eye in the Sky*, *Time Out of Joint*, and *Martian Time-Slip*, and argues that for Dick the common world is a maintained artifact. Chapter 2 follows the Gnostic lineage from Plato's cave and the archons of the Nag Hammadi codices to *VALIS*, and argues that Dick's Gnosticism is reparative rather than escapist. Chapter 3 reconstructs Dick's physics of decay, from Clausius to Schrödinger and Shannon, through kipple, gubble, and the Form Destroyer, and argues that maintenance is his cosmology.

Part Two examines the counterfeit and its critics. Chapter 4 treats the commodity and the simulacrum; Chapter 5, the android and the test of the human; Chapter 6, drugs and sacraments as *pharmaka*; Chapter 7, schizophrenia and paranoia as hermeneutic machines; Chapter 8, the 1974 experiences, the *Exegesis*, and the theology of a damaged God. Part Three synthesises. Chapter 9 formulates reparative ontology, distinguishes three models of healing (the Hegelian, the Wagnerian, and the kintsugi), identifies the repairman as Dick's characteristic hero, and states the *Tractatus Reparativus*. Chapter 10 extends the theory to simulation, machine minds, and the Anthropocene.

The dissertation makes six claims to originality. It reframes Dick's oeuvre, through Kleinian and Sedgwickian theory, as a passage from paranoid to reparative positions. It identifies the repairman and the potter as structural rather than incidental figures, recurring across *Galactic Pot-Healer*, *The Three Stigmata of Palmer Eldritch*, *Flow My Tears, the Policeman Said*, *Martian Time-Slip*, and *The Man in the High Castle*. It distinguishes three models of healing and locates Dick's in the third. It formalises the trash stratum as a kenotic gradient. It reads the late theology through Lurianic Kabbalah and Origenist restoration rather than through Valentinian escape, placing Dick within a twentieth-century tradition of the damaged and dependent God. And it extends the resulting ontology to the philosophy of simulation, the ethics of artificial minds, and the debate in environmental philosophy over the value of restored nature.

PART ONE



Genealogies of the Unreal

Part One reconstructs the intellectual lineages from which Dick assembled his unreal worlds: the phenomenology of private and common worlds, the Gnostic counter-cosmology, and the physics of entropy. Each genealogy is traced to its originators and followed to the point at which Dick bends it. In each case the bend is the same. What the tradition treats as a condition to be diagnosed or escaped, Dick treats as a condition to be maintained.

CHAPTER

1

Idios Kosmos

Private Worlds and the Labour of the Common



> *τοῖς ἐγρηγορόσιν ἕνα καὶ κοινὸν κόσμον εἶναι, τῶν δὲ κοιμωμένων ἕκαστον εἰς ἴδιον ἀποστρέφεσθαι.*
>
> For those who are awake there is one common world, but each sleeper turns away into a world of his own.
>
> Heraclitus, fr. B89 DK, preserved in Plutarch, *De superstitione* 166c

1.1 *Heraclitus and the Duty of Wakefulness*

The distinction between the *idios kosmos* and the *koinos kosmos*, which Dick adopted as the master opposition of his metaphysics, reaches us in a sentence whose wording is itself uncertain. Fragment B89 survives only in Plutarch, and philologists have long debated how much of its phrasing belongs to Heraclitus and how much to his reporter (see Kahn 1979). The doctrine it encodes, however, is securely attested. Heraclitus complains that although the logos is common (*xynos*), the many live as though they possessed a private understanding (B2); that men fail to notice what they do when awake just as they forget what they do asleep (B1); and that those who would speak with sense must hold fast to what is common to all, as a city holds fast to its law, and more firmly still (B114).

The common world, on this account, is not simply there. It is a normative achievement, sustained by wakefulness in the way a polis is sustained by law, and it can be abandoned by those who retreat into the private sleep of opinion.

Three further fragments complete the Heraclitean inheritance. The cosmos is an ever-living fire, kindling in measures and going out in measures (B30): order is not an inert substrate but a regulated process of combustion and renewal. An unapparent harmony is stronger than an apparent one (B54): the truth of things lies in a latent fitting-together of tensions, like that of the bow and the lyre. And nature loves to hide (B123). A world that is a process, whose true order is latent, and whose commonality depends on the wakefulness of its inhabitants, is already a world that must be maintained. The Heraclitean *koinos kosmos* is the first model of what this dissertation calls reparative ontology: a common reality that exists only so long as it is kept.

1.2 *The Existential-Psychiatric Relay*

Dick did not receive Heraclitus directly from the doxographers. He received him through a twentieth-century relay whose importance for his work has been underestimated. In "Traum und Existenz" (1930), Ludwig Binswanger made the passage from B89 central to a phenomenology of dreaming: the dreamer turns away from the shared world into a private one, and dreaming is thereby disclosed as a mode of existence rather than a mere mental event. The essay proved doubly consequential. Its French translation (1954) carried a long introduction by the young Michel Foucault, his first publication. And Binswanger's *Daseinsanalyse*, which adapted Heidegger's analysis of being-in-the-world (*In-der-Welt-sein*) to psychiatric description, became through the anthology *Existence* (May, Angel, and Ellenberger 1958) the principal channel by which European phenomenological psychiatry reached American readers. That volume contained Binswanger's "The Case of Ellen West," with its analysis of a patient whose existence was torn between an ethereal world and a tomb-world (*Gruftwelt*), and Eugène Minkowski's "Findings in a Case of Schizophrenic Depression." Dick's tomb world, which structures the eschatology of *Martian Time-Slip* and the myth of Mercer in *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?*, descends from this source.

Dick made the relay explicit in "Schizophrenia & The Book of Changes" (1965), where the schizophrenic appears as one who has fallen out of the *koinos kosmos* into an *idios kosmos* that others cannot enter, and where the *I Ching*, with its cosmology

of patterned change and Jung's theory of meaningful coincidence (Jung 1950; 1952), is proposed as an instrument oriented toward exactly those junctures at which the shared world gives way. The psychiatric literature supplied Dick with more than a vocabulary. Minkowski had described schizophrenia as a loss of vital contact with reality (*perte du contact vital avec la réalité*, 1927) and had analysed the patient's lived time (*le temps vécu*, 1933) as a becoming arrested and spatialised, a future no longer open but already present as decay. Wolfgang Blankenburg (1971) would characterise the condition as a loss of natural self-evidence (*Verlust der natürlichen Selbstverständlichkeit*): the patient no longer finds the world obvious, and must reconstruct by reflection what others inhabit without thought. Louis Sass (1992) generalised the point into a revision of the romantic image of madness. Schizophrenia, on his account, is less a Dionysian flood of the irrational than a hyper-Apollonian hyperreflexivity, a pathological self-consciousness in which the tacit becomes explicit and the world is observed rather than lived.

Dick's schizophrenics are Sass's rather than the counterculture's. Jack Bohlen's formative breakdown in *Martian Time-Slip* consists in seeing his personnel manager as an assemblage of wires and batteries: an excess, not a deficit, of analytic regard. Dick's theoretical gloss on such experiences, sustained across the essays and the *Exegesis*, is Kantian. If space and time are, as the *Critique of Pure Reason* (1781; 1787) argues, the a priori forms of intuition through which any experience whatever is constituted, then psychosis is not the false perception of a true world but a failure of world-constitution itself, a collapse of the forms that make a common world possible.

The phenomenological tradition supplies the positive counterpart of this insight. For Husserl the objective world is intersubjectively constituted, co-produced by a community of perceivers (*Cartesianische Meditationen*, 1931, Fifth Meditation). For Alfred Schutz (1945) everyday life is the paramount reality among multiple finite provinces of meaning, from which we are displaced by shocks. For Peter Berger and Thomas Luckmann (1966) subjective reality must be continuously sustained by social processes they called *reality-maintenance*, conversation above all, and Berger (1967) extended the concept to religion as *world-maintenance* underwritten by plausibility structures. Maurice Merleau-Ponty's perceptual faith (*foi perceptive*, 1964) names the tacit trust whose fragility the whole tradition registers. Dick's novels of the late 1950s and 1960s are experiments in what happens when maintenance fails.

1.3 Eye in the Sky*: Berkeley's Tyranny*

In *Eye in the Sky* (1957) a malfunction at the Belmont Bevatron precipitates eight people through a collapsing observation platform into the proton beam. They awaken into a succession of worlds, each the private cosmos of one member of the group, which all must inhabit while that consciousness dominates. The first belongs to Arthur Silvester, adherent of a fundamentalist sect, in whose cosmos prayer is answered with mechanical literalism, sin is punished by plague, and the heavens contain the enormous eye that gives the novel its title. Edith Pritchet's world is governed by her distaste: whole categories of existence she finds offensive are abolished, until the world thins toward nothing. Joan Reiss's world is paranoid, its objects turned hostile; Charley McFeyffe's is a crude Communist caricature.

The novel is a Berkeleyan experiment with a political edge. In the *Treatise Concerning the Principles of Human Knowledge* (1710), George Berkeley argued that for sensible things to be is to be perceived (*esse est percipi*), and that the continuity of the world is guaranteed by its perception in the mind of God. Dick removes Berkeley's divine perceiver and installs a finite and partisan one, with a consequence Berkeley never contemplated: the private world is not merely unreal but coercive. Whoever's *idios kosmos* is dominant, everyone else must live inside it. The satire is precise. The protagonist, Jack Hamilton, has lost his defence-industry position because his wife's political associations make him a security risk, and the security officer who hounds him proves to be the committed ideologue. Written in the aftermath of the loyalty-oath regime, *Eye in the Sky* diagnoses McCarthyism as the imposition of one faction's *idios kosmos* upon the *koinos kosmos* of a republic.

The coincidence of dates is instructive. In the same year Hugh Everett III published his relative-state formulation of quantum mechanics (1957), which dissolved the privileged observer into a branching plurality of observer-correlated states; four years later Eugene Wigner (1961) asked whether the consciousness of an observer's friend is required to complete a measurement. Dick's novel stages a sociology of observation in which observers are plural and competitive, and in which the common world is what remains when no single observer is permitted to dominate. Its return to consensus reality is a collaborative achievement and the first sketch of a thesis the later work will deepen: the *koinos kosmos* is a political artifact, and its maintenance a civic labour.

1.4 Time Out of Joint: *The Maintained Counterfeit*

Time Out of Joint (1959) is the canonical Dickian revelation. Ragle Gumm lives in a small American town of the 1950s and supports himself by winning, every day, a newspaper contest that asks where a little green man will appear next. Anomalies accumulate. A soft-drink stand dissolves before his eyes, leaving only a slip of paper bearing its name; his brother-in-law gropes for a light cord that is not there, his body remembering a different room; a radio picks up aircraft chatter that seems to concern Ragle himself; a magazine carries the image of a famous actress whom nobody in town can name. The town is a constructed environment built around Ragle in the late 1990s, its inhabitants complicit or conditioned, its purpose to keep him performing, in the guise of a harmless game, the calculation that predicts the targets of missile strikes launched by lunar colonists at war with Earth.

Criticism has privileged the revelation that the world is fake. Jameson (1991) read the novel as the 1950s' image of itself, a nostalgia for the present produced from within it; Slavoj Žižek (2002) found in it the template of the American paranoid fantasy later filmed as *The Truman Show* (1998). The novel belongs to a distinguished lineage, from Robert A. Heinlein's "They" (1941), whose protagonist suspects that the world is staged for his benefit, through Frederik Pohl's "The Tunnel Under the World" (1955), in which a town relives a single day as a miniature laboratory for advertising, to Daniel F. Galouye's *Simulacron-3* (1964) and Rainer Werner Fassbinder's *Welt am Draht* (1973), which Mark Fisher (2016) set beside Dick in his analysis of the eerie. The slip of paper that replaces the soft-drink stand has an equally distinguished philosophical ancestry. It literalises Alfred Korzybski's dictum that the map is not the territory (*Science and Sanity*, 1933), mediated through A. E. van Vogt's *The World of Null-A* (1948), a novel Dick repeatedly acknowledged.

What the paranoid reading misses is the economy of the revelation. The counterfeit town is staggeringly expensive. It requires staff, props, supply chains, continuous surveillance, and constant repair, and when it fails it fails not because it is false but because it has not been adequately maintained: the soft-drink stand vanishes because the upkeep of a single object has lapsed. *Time Out of Joint* thus discloses that the fake is a maintained artifact, and by implication that the real, whatever its ultimate status, is maintained as well. The title, taken from *Hamlet* (I.v), carries the second half of the insight. Jacques Derrida would open *Spectres de Marx* (1993) with the same line, reading the disjointure of time as the condition of justice, the dislocation that calls for setting right. Ragle's final choice, to side with the

lunar colonists against the government that has confined him, is a refusal of maintained illusion and a gesture of solidarity with the dispossessed. Hamlet's curse is the repairman's vocation: to be born into a time out of joint is to be charged with setting it right.

1.5 Martian Time-Slip*: Gubble, the Tomb World, and Lived Time*

Martian Time-Slip (1964) is Dick's most sustained engagement with phenomenological psychiatry and the first of his novels whose protagonist is a repairman. On a water-starved Martian colony, the union boss Arnie Kott seeks to exploit the precognitive perception of Manfred Steiner, a boy the novel describes in the terms of its era as autistic and schizophrenic, in order to anticipate a United Nations development scheme and profit from land speculation. Jack Bohlen, a repairman who once suffered a schizophrenic episode, becomes the mediator between Kott's enterprise and Manfred's world. The novel's conflation of autism with schizophrenia, and its reliance on then-prevalent psychogenic theories of childhood disorder, belong to the psychiatric history it absorbed and have long since been abandoned.

Manfred perceives time as already accomplished decay. He sees the future ruin of every body and building, a process he names *gubble* or *gubbish*, and he foresees his own old age in AM-WEB, a future housing complex whose name abbreviates Schiller's *Alle Menschen werden Brüder* and in which his aged body will be sustained by machines. This is Minkowski's spatialised lived time rendered as narrative: a future that no longer opens but has already arrived as corruption. It is also Augustine's analysis of time as the distension of the mind (*distentio animi*) among memory, attention, and expectation (*Confessiones* XI), collapsed into expectation alone. Dick gives the collapse formal expression in the celebrated sequence in which a single evening is narrated repeatedly, each iteration more thoroughly invaded by the boy's perception, until the language of the narrative itself begins to decompose. The tomb world, inherited from Binswanger's Ellen West, becomes the terminus toward which Manfred's perception drags every object.

Against Kott's instrumentalisation of Manfred, the novel sets two alternatives. The first is Jack's: the repairman who can enter another's time because he has lived inside a broken world himself, and whose relation to the boy is less therapeutic correction than companionship in breakdown. The second is that of the Bleekmen, the dispossessed indigenous Martians, treated by the colonists with a contempt that transposes the racial order of the American West to Mars, whose own tempo-

ral sense accommodates Manfred's and who receive him when the colonial order cannot. The colony's school, with its simulacral teaching machines reproducing a curated Earth heritage, is the institution of the colonial *koinos kosmos*; the Bleekmen are its outside. *Martian Time-Slip* thereby refuses both the romantic celebration of the psychotic vision and the psychiatric project of forcible readjustment. The psychotic world, it suggests, is not an illusion to be corrected but a world that has not been maintained in common, and its remedy lies in the patient work of those who can dwell in two worlds at once.

1.6 *Butterflies, Lathes, and Consensual Hallucinations*

The oldest analogue of Dick's problematic is Chinese rather than Greek. At the close of the second chapter of the *Zhuangzi*, Zhuang Zhou dreams that he is a butterfly and, waking, cannot tell whether he is a man who dreamed he was a butterfly or a butterfly now dreaming that it is a man; the text names this indeterminacy the transformation of things (*wuhua*). Zhuangzi's response is not to adjudicate but to affirm the passage between states. Ursula K. Le Guin's *The Lathe of Heaven* (1971), often read as her most Dickian novel, dramatises the ethical stakes. George Orr's dreams retroactively alter reality; his psychiatrist, Haber, seizes on the power to engineer a better world, and each intervention produces a new catastrophe. Le Guin's answer is Taoist non-forcing (*wu wei*). Dick's answer, as the following chapters show, is different: not to refrain from intervention but to intervene as repair rather than as design. Both novelists nevertheless identify the same antagonist. Haber is what Kleinian theory calls a manic reparer, one who mends the world omnipotently and contemptuously, without the humility that acknowledges damage and dependence (see Chapter 7).

William Gibson's definition of cyberspace in *Neuromancer* (1984) as a consensual hallucination shared daily by billions marks the terminus of the lineage: the *koinos kosmos* as commercial infrastructure, maintained by corporations and sold as a service. Between Heraclitus's city holding fast to its law and Gibson's matrix lies the history that Dick's fiction compresses, and the first premise of reparative ontology follows from it. The common world is neither simply given nor simply constructed. It is a maintained artifact, produced and reproduced by conversation, attention, institutions, and care, and the decisive question it poses is not whether it is real but who maintains it, at whose expense, and for whom.

CHAPTER

2

The Counterfeit Cosmos

Gnosis, the Demiurge, and the Black Iron Prison



> *Split a piece of wood, and I am there. Lift up the stone, and you will find me there.*
>
> Gospel of Thomas, logion 77 (Nag Hammadi Codex II, 2)

2.1 *From the Cave to the Archons*

The Western archetype of the counterfeit world is a manufactured one. In the allegory of *Republic* VII (514a–520a), the prisoners do not watch natural shadows. They watch shadows cast by artifacts (*skeuē*) carried along a wall behind them by unseen bearers, so that the cave is less a condition of ignorance than a puppet theatre, a world kept in operation by the continuous labour of its operators. The first counterfeit world in Western philosophy is therefore already a maintained one. The *Timaeus* supplies the counterpart figure of the maker. Its demiurge (*dēmiourgos*, literally a public worker or artisan) is a benevolent craftsman who, being good and free of envy, fashions the cosmos after an eternal model and makes it as good as its materials allow (29e–30a), so that time itself becomes a moving image of eternity (37d). Plato's cosmos is a work of craftsmanship, and its maker is a repairman of chaos.

The Gnostic systems of the second century inverted both figures. In the *Apocryphon of John*, the craftsman becomes Ialdabaoth, a monstrous offspring of Sophia's unsanctioned desire, who fashions the lower world in ignorance of the realm above him and proclaims himself the only god. His archons administer *heimarmenē*, the astral fate that binds souls through the planetary spheres; human beings carry a spark of the higher light imprisoned in matter; salvation is *gnōsis*, the saving recollection of origin that permits the spark to pass the archons and return to the Pleroma. Valentinian theology, reconstructed largely from Irenaeus's polemic *Adversus haereses* (c. 180), elaborated a Pleroma of aeons, the passion and fall of Sophia, and a psychic Demiurge who labours in ignorance of what lies above him. Manichaeism radicalised the dualism into two coeternal principles of Light and Darkness whose catastrophic mixture constitutes the visible world, and assigned to its Elect the task of liberating particles of light trapped in matter, notably by the ritual consumption of food.

The modern reception of this material was shaped decisively by Hans Jonas, Heidegger's student, whose *Gnosis und spätantiker Geist* (1934) and English synthesis *The Gnostic Religion* (1958) read Gnosis existentially: the self is thrown (the Gnostic texts themselves use the image) into an alien world by an alien power and hears a call from beyond it. In the epilogue to the 1958 volume Jonas argued that modern existentialism is a Gnosticism without a transcendent God. The discovery in December 1945 of the Nag Hammadi codices, published in English as *The Nag Hammadi Library* (Robinson 1977), turned a heresy known chiefly through its enemies into a corpus that could be read in its own voice. Dick read that corpus in the late 1970s, and it enters *VALIS* as the burial site of the living information he called the plasmate, dormant in the codices until they were unearthed.

2.2 *Dualist Apprenticeship*

Dick's dualism long predates Nag Hammadi. In *The Cosmic Puppets* (1957) Ted Barton returns to the Virginia town of his childhood to find it altered beyond recognition, its streets renamed and his own childhood death recorded in the local newspaper. The town has been overlaid by a counterfeit, the battlefield of a contest between Ormazd and Ahriman, the Ahura Mazda and Angra Mainyu of Zoroastrian cosmology, in which the townspeople are pieces moved by powers they cannot perceive. The novel transposes into the idiom of the small-town mys-

tery the modern philosophical form of the Gnostic demiurge, Descartes's hypothesis in the first *Meditation* (1641) of an evil genius (*genius malignus*), supremely powerful and cunning, who has employed all his energies to deceive.

"Faith of Our Fathers" (1967), Dick's contribution to Harlan Ellison's *Dangerous Visions*, gives the demiurge a mouth. A minor functionary in a Communist-governed world takes what he is told is an anti-hallucinogen and discovers that the water supply has been dosed with hallucinogens that render the Absolute Benefactor of the People as a man. Seen undrugged, the Benefactor is a protean, predatory entity that different witnesses perceive differently, and whose relation to human beings is that of an eater to its food. The story's theological conclusion is that the Benefactor is God. Its psychological conclusion, which Chapter 7 develops, is that the revelation of the true god in Dick's early work is the revelation of an appetite.

The Three Stigmata of Palmer Eldritch (1965) is the summit of the dualist apprenticeship. Eldritch returns from the Proxima system with a hallucinogen, Chew-Z, and with three stigmata that parody the five wounds of the crucified Christ as prosthetics: an artificial arm, steel teeth, and artificial eyes. Those who chew Chew-Z enter worlds that Eldritch inhabits and ultimately owns; the stigmata spread until the protagonists perceive them on everyone, themselves included. Eldritch is thus a demiurge in the strict Gnostic sense, the craftsman of a counterfeit world offered as salvation, and possibly something worse, an entity that devoured the traveller who went out to Proxima and returned in his shape. Yet the novel's epigraph, presented as an interoffice memo dictated by the Perky Pat magnate Leo Bulero on his return from Mars, strikes a different note. It reflects that human beings are made of dust, that this is not much to begin with, and that, considering so meagre a beginning, they have not done badly. The memo is written after the events of the novel, by a man who has been inside the demiurge's world and resolved to resist it. Its humility is not Gnostic contempt for matter. It is a creature's rueful respect for the poor material it is made of, and it prefigures the depressive position toward which the oeuvre moves.

2.3 *Theologies of the Simulation: The Efficacious Fraud*

A Maze of Death (1970) inverts the Gnostic scenario by making the prisoners the architects of their prison. Fourteen colonists arrive on the planet Delmak-O, a world governed by a fully articulated theology, which Dick's foreword credits to discus-

sions with William Sarill, of four divine persons: the Mentufacturer, the Intercessor, the Walker-on-Earth, and the Form Destroyer. Prayer is transmitted mechanically and answered. As the colonists die one by one, the truth emerges: they are the crew of a disabled starship in hopeless orbit around a dead star, sustaining their sanity through a shared simulation generated from their collective psyche, and the theology is their own invention. A Gnostic novel would end here, with the disclosure of the counterfeit. Dick's does not. At the last, the Intercessor appears to Seth Morley outside the simulation, in the reality of the ship, and offers him release: the fabricated god proves efficacious beyond the fabrication.

The structure recurs in *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?* (1968), where the television host Buster Friendly exposes Wilbur Mercer, the suffering figure whose ascent of a hill unites believers through the empathy box, as a bit-part actor named Al Jarry filmed on a soundstage. The exposure changes nothing that matters. Mercer appears to J. R. Isidore after the broadcast, and later to Rick Deckard, in the desert, without any box at all. In Dick, the unmasking of a religion as fabrication does not terminate its efficacy. It inaugurates a second relation to the sacred, one that no longer depends on the authenticity of origin, and in this sense Dick reverses Ludwig Feuerbach, for whom the demonstration that God is a human projection was the end of theology. For Dick it is where theology begins.

Stanisław Lem arrived at the same problem in the same season from the opposite direction. "Non Serviam" (1971), a fictional review in *Doskonała próżnia* (*A Perfect Vacuum*), describes the personoids of a computational experiment who develop rival theologies of their unknown Creator and debate whether they owe him worship; the reviewed professor confesses the ethical vertigo of a maker who may one day switch off the machine. Lem writes from the Creator's burden, Dick from the creatures' need. Together the two works, written within months of one another, constitute the founding documents of what Chapter 10 treats as the theology of simulation.

2.4 VALIS*: Orthogonal Time and the Empire That Never Ended*

VALIS (1981) splits its narrator in two. "Phil," a science-fiction writer, recounts the religious crisis of his friend Horselover Fat, whose name is a bilingual translation of the author's own (Greek *philippos*, lover of horses; German *dick*, fat). Fat's breakdown begins with his failure to prevent a friend's suicide and deepens into a theophany: a beam of pink light that transmits information, heals, and dissolves the

boundary between 1974 California and first-century Rome. The appendix to the novel, the *Tractates Cryptica Scriptura*, compresses Fat's theology into fifty-two entries whose central claim is the most quoted sentence Dick ever wrote: *the Empire never ended*. Historical time, on this account, stopped with the destruction of the Temple in 70 CE and resumed in 1974; the intervening centuries are an interpolated counterfeit; and the Roman Empire persists as a spiritual structure of domination Dick calls the Black Iron Prison. Against it stands the Palm Tree Garden, the recollected world of the early Christian community, which breaks through the prison at points of grace.

The cosmology of the *Tractates* is a two-source theory. The One, wishing to be born, generated a dyad: two hyperuniverses, the first rational and luminous, the second, identified with the Parmenidean form of darkness, which fell ill and became blind and irrational. Our universe is the hologram produced by their interference. To heal the ailing second hyperuniverse, the first sent into it a microform of itself, a living information that Dick identifies variously with Christ, the Buddha, Elijah, and the physician-god Asklepios, and that can cross-bond with human beings to produce what he calls homoplasmates. The temporal theory is equally striking. In "Man, Android, and Machine" (1976) Dick had proposed an orthogonal time in which all forms of an event coexist along an axis perpendicular to linear succession. *VALIS* finds the same insight in Gurnemanz's line in Act I of *Parsifal*: *zum Raum wird hier die Zeit* (here time becomes space).

Three older structures illuminate the doctrine. Mircea Eliade's *Le mythe de l'éternel retour* (1949) describes the archaic abolition of profane history through ritual return to the sacred time of origins (*illud tempus*), which is precisely what 1974 accomplishes for Fat. Augustine's *De civitate Dei* describes two cities, the earthly and the heavenly, founded on two loves and intermingled (*permixtae*) throughout history until the end; the Black Iron Prison and the Palm Tree Garden coexist in Orange County as Augustine's cities coexisted in Rome. And Boethius, defining divine eternity as the complete, simultaneous, and perfect possession of illimitable life (*interminabilis vitae tota simul et perfecta possessio*, *Consolatio* V), supplies the model of the vision that Fat is granted: the view of time from the axis orthogonal to it.

2.5 *Voegelin Inverted, Blumenberg Reversed*

The Empire of *VALIS* is a political category. *Radio Free Albemuth*, written in 1976 and published posthumously in 1985, makes the reference explicit: its tyrant, Ferris F. Fremont, rises to the presidency through anticommunist paranoia in transparent allegory of Richard Nixon, and the satellite intelligence VALIS broadcasts subversive information to dissidents through popular music. Dick's political Gnosticism thereby inverts the most influential twentieth-century use of the category. For Eric Voegelin (*The New Science of Politics*, 1952; *Wissenschaft, Politik und Gnosis*, 1959), the modern mass movements, from positivism through Marxism to National Socialism, are Gnostic because they immanentise the eschaton, promising salvation within history through a saving knowledge in the possession of an elite. The Gnostic, for Voegelin, is the totalitarian. For Dick the Gnostic is the dissident, the immanentised false kingdom is the Empire itself, and gnosis is samizdat.

Hans Blumenberg's *Die Legitimität der Neuzeit* (1966) supplies the deeper frame. Blumenberg argued that the modern age constitutes the second overcoming of Gnosticism. Augustine's first overcoming failed because it merely transferred the origin of evil from a malign creator to human freedom, and late-medieval nominalism, with its inscrutable and absolutely sovereign God, re-Gnosticised the world; modernity overcame Gnosticism a second time through human self-assertion, taking responsibility for a world no longer guaranteed by providence. Dick's fiction runs Blumenberg's thesis backward. In his worlds technoscientific self-assertion does not overcome the demiurge; it becomes one. Palmer Eldritch is a corporate adventurer; the Empire of *VALIS* is administered by security states and mass media; the archons wear business suits. Dick's novels are laboratories in which the second overcoming of Gnosticism is rerun and fails, so that the demiurge returns in the shape of the very self-assertion that was to banish it.

The comparative lineage clarifies what is distinctive in Dick's version. David Lindsay's *A Voyage to Arcturus* (1920), the founding text of Gnostic fantasy, sends its hero across the planet Tormance to discover that the world's pleasures are the lures of a counterfeit creator, Crystalman, and that the real lies elsewhere, in Muspel. Harold Bloom modelled his own Gnostic fantasy, *The Flight to Lucifer* (1979), on Lindsay, and Galbreath's comparison of it with *VALIS* is the source of the phrase ironic Gnosticism. William Gibson's *Count Zero* (1986) imagines the unified machine intelligence of *Neuromancer* shattered into fragments that manifest in cyberspace as the *loa* of Haitian Vodou, a cybernetic gnosis whose gods are the

broken pieces of a single mind. And *The Matrix* (1999) delivered the Gnostic plot to mass culture intact: a counterfeit world maintained by machines, a saving knowledge administered as a pill, an elect who awaken and escape.

2.6 *Reparative Gnosticism*

Dick is not a Gnostic in the strict sense, and the reasons are structural rather than doctrinal. The first concerns the direction of salvation. In the classical systems, the spark escapes: the soul ascends past the archons and returns to the Pleroma, and the cosmos is abandoned to its maker. In Dick's two-source cosmogony the movement runs the other way. A healing microform descends into the damaged universe in order to repair it from within. The plasmate is not an exit but a medicine, and the sick hyperuniverse is not a prison to be fled but a patient to be treated.

The second concerns the location of the divine. The Gnostic despises matter as the substance of the prison. Dick's divine hides in the most degraded matter available: in the trash stratum, in what the *Exegesis* calls Zebra, a mimetic intelligence camouflaged so perfectly in the environment that it is indistinguishable from it. The Nag Hammadi text most congenial to Dick is accordingly the least cosmologically dualist: the Gospel of Thomas, whose logion 77 locates the divine in split wood and a lifted stone, the stuff of the woodpile and the roadside.

The third concerns the model of the saviour. Irenaeus's answer to the Valentinians was the doctrine of recapitulation (*anakephalaiōsis*, *Adversus haereses* III.18; V.21), in which Christ gathers up and re-heads the whole of creation, restoring rather than abandoning it. Recapitulation is a theology of repair devised expressly against Gnosis. Dick's late theology, in which an ailing universe is healed by an indwelling microform, is closer in structure to Irenaeus's recapitulation, and to the Origenist restoration of all things examined in Chapter 8, than to Valentinus. Dick's heresy is Gnostic in vocabulary and Irenaean in structure. Galbreath called it ironic Gnosticism; this dissertation names the content of the irony *reparative Gnosticism*, a contradiction in terms that accurately describes a heresy in which the prison is not escaped but mended from within, and in which the Palm Tree Garden grows, as Augustine's heavenly city grew, inside the walls of the earthly one.

CHAPTER

3

Kipple, Gubble, and the Form Destroyer

Entropy, Information, and the Physics of Decay



> *Die Energie der Welt ist constant. Die Entropie der Welt strebt einem Maximum zu.*
>
> The energy of the world is constant. The entropy of the world tends toward a maximum.
>
> Rudolf Clausius, *Über verschiedene für die Anwendung bequeme Formen der Hauptgleichungen der mechanischen Wärmetheorie* (1865)

3.1 *The Thermodynamic Imaginary*

Clausius coined *entropy* in 1865 from the Greek *tropē*, transformation, to name the quantity that measures a system's irreversible tendency toward equilibrium. Ludwig Boltzmann's statistical interpretation (1877) recast it as a measure of the number of microscopic arrangements compatible with a macroscopic state, a relation later engraved on his tomb in Vienna, and Hermann von Helmholtz and William Thomson drew from the second law the prospect of a heat death in which all differences of temperature, and hence all work, would cease. The thermodynamic imaginary passed quickly into cultural theory. Henry Adams's "A Letter to American Teachers of History" (1910) applied the second law

to civilisation and predicted the dissipation of social energy. Yevgeny Zamyatin's essay on literature, revolution, and entropy (1923) opposed the energy of heresy to the entropy of dogma, a dialectic his novel *We* had already dramatised.

Science fiction absorbed the imaginary as cosmology and as mood. Isaac Asimov's "The Last Question" (1956) follows a computer, interrogated across aeons about whether entropy can be reversed, until at the heat death, having absorbed the remnants of human minds, it answers with the fiat of Genesis: the Logos as negentropy. Thomas Pynchon's "Entropy" (1960) sets a sealed hothouse against a disintegrating party, and *The Crying of Lot 49* (1966) couples a machine that purports to realise Maxwell's demon with an underground postal system that names itself W.A.S.T.E. J. G. Ballard's *The Drowned World* (1962) renders entropy as biological regression toward the Triassic. Pamela Zoline's "The Heat Death of the Universe" (1967), published in *New Worlds*, interleaves a housewife's day of cooking, cleaning, and childcare with numbered paragraphs on thermodynamics, until domestic maintenance and cosmic dissipation become the same struggle and the heroine, at the end, begins to break things. Dick's place in this imaginary is distinctive. He makes entropy tactile, domestic, and moral. His decay is not a remote cosmological fate but the lint in the apartment, the stale cigarette, the junk mail, and his question is not whether the universe will run down but who, meanwhile, will keep things going.

3.2 *A Taxonomy of Decay*

Dick's vocabulary of decay is the most inventive in twentieth-century fiction, and its terms are not synonyms. *Kipple*, in *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?*, is J. R. Isidore's name for useless objects, such as junk mail, empty match folders, gum wrappers, and yesterday's newspaper, which reproduce themselves when no one is present. Isidore formulates a law, *kipple drives out nonkipple*, which parodies Gresham's law of currency and states the second law of thermodynamics in the idiom of the dump, and he foresees a universe moving toward total and absolute kippleisation. Kipple is entropy with a sociology: it accumulates where people are absent. Isidore lives alone in a decaying building of empty apartments on a planet depopulated by World War Terminus, and the kipple is the visible form of that absence.

Gubble, in *Martian Time-Slip*, is Manfred Steiner's word for the organic corruption he perceives beneath all surfaces, the future rot of bodies and buildings already present to his sight. Where kipple is the accumulation of dead objects, gubble is the decomposition of living ones, and its terminus is the tomb world. The *Form Destroyer*, in the constructed theology of *A Maze of Death*, personifies the same process as a divine person, the principle of decay set against the Mentufacturer who makes forms and the Intercessor who redeems them. Dick's taxonomy thus distinguishes three registers of entropy: the social (kipple, the debris of absence), the organic (gubble, the corruption of the living), and the metaphysical (the Form Destroyer, the unmaking of form as such).

Ubik (1969) adds a fourth, the historical, and it is the most original. After a bomb on the Moon kills their employer, Glen Runciter, the technician Joe Chip and his colleagues find their world regressing. Cigarettes are stale, cream is sour, coins bear obsolete designs, a modern elevator becomes an open cage, aircraft become Ford Trimotors, and the world settles by stages into the Des Moines of 1939, while members of the group are discovered desiccated into husks. One of Joe's colleagues proposes a Platonic explanation: each object contains the sequence of its prior forms, and as the energy sustaining its present form is exhausted, earlier forms surface. Dick here fuses Plato with Clausius. The eternal *eidos* becomes a stratigraphy of obsolete designs, and entropy is not the dissolution of form into homogeneous heat but the return of the formal past. Decay, in *Ubik*, is haunting. The regression anticipates what Mark Fisher (2014), borrowing Franco Berardi's phrase, would call the slow cancellation of the future, rendered as a physics.

3.3 Ubik*: Negentropy as Commodity and Logos*

Against the regression stands a single substance. Ubik, whose name Dick derived from the Latin *ubique*, everywhere, arrives in a spray can. Each chapter of the novel opens with an advertisement for Ubik in a different guise, as beer, coffee, salad dressing, a savings plan, a razor, until the final chapter's epigraph gives Ubik the voice of the Johannine Logos, claiming precedence over the universe and identity with the word. The theological audacity of the device lies in its route. The negentropic principle must pass through the commodity form to reach those it saves. The Word does not descend into flesh but into an aerosol, and it is marketed with the same idiom as a breakfast cereal. This is the kenotic gradient in its purest pre-1974 form: the divine enters the world at the level of the jingle and the label.

The messages that guide Joe through the regression confirm the principle. They appear on a matchbook cover, on a label, in a television commercial, and as graffiti on the wall of a toilet stall: Runciter speaks from the other side of death through the humblest media available, the literal trash stratum of the novel's world. And the ontology of the half-life in which the characters are trapped is structured by two economies. Ella Runciter, Glen's wife, lying in cold-pac at the Beloved Brethren Moratorium in Zurich, supplies Ubik to protect the half-lifers. Jory Miller, a half-lifer who sustains himself by consuming the residual vitality of others, fabricates the regressing world and devours its inhabitants. Preservation against consumption, gift against predation, maintenance against the devouring mouth: the metaphysical conflict of *Ubik* is a conflict between two relations to the depleted, and it is resolved, provisionally, by Ella's decision to entrust the fight to Joe before she is reborn.

The novel's notorious final turn, in which Runciter, apparently alive, finds Joe Chip's profile on his own coins, denies any character a secure ontological frame. Criticism has read it as the triumph of ontological uncertainty. It is equally legible as a statement about maintenance. No position in *Ubik* is guaranteed from outside; every world is sustained only by a substance that must be applied, and applied again. Joe Chip is not a hero of revelation but of upkeep, a man perpetually in debt, whose own apartment door demands a coin before it will open and threatens litigation when he refuses, and whose salvation consists in continuing to spray.

3.4 *Living Information*

Erwin Schrödinger's *What Is Life?* (1944) proposed that an organism maintains its improbable order by feeding on negative entropy, drawing order from its environment, and that heredity must be carried by an aperiodic crystal functioning as a code-script, the hypothesis that the discovery of the structure of DNA (1953) vindicated. Norbert Wiener's *Cybernetics* (1948) and *The Human Use of Human Beings* (1950) identified information with negentropy and described organisms and machines alike as local islands of decreasing entropy in a universe that runs down. Claude Shannon's "A Mathematical Theory of Communication" (1948) defined information as a measure of the reduction of uncertainty, deliberately indifferent to meaning, and Léon Brillouin (1956) formalised the equivalence of information and negentropy.

Dick's plasmate is a hybrid of these conceptions and an alteration of all of them. It is living information: self-replicating like Schrödinger's code-script, negentropic like Wiener's feedback, but purposive and semantic in a way Shannon's measure excludes. The *Tractates* assert that the universe is information and that human perception hypostatises information into the appearance of a physical world, a thesis that anticipates John Archibald Wheeler's proposal (1990) that physical reality arises from the answers to yes-or-no questions, *it from bit*. Three later concepts sharpen the difference. Richard Dawkins's meme (1976) is a replicator indifferent to its host; William S. Burroughs's language virus (*The Ticket That Exploded*, 1962) is parasitic and controlling; Shannon's bit is semantically blank. Dick's plasmate is therapeutic. It enters the human brain as a symbiont in order to heal, and the cosmology of the two hyperuniverses makes the healing of a damaged universe its purpose. Information, in Dick's theology, is negentropy with intention: a Logos that repairs.

3.5 *Maintenance as Cosmology*

The philosophical significance of Dick's physics of decay appears most clearly against Heidegger's analysis of equipment in *Sein und Zeit* (1927, §16). Equipment in use is ready-to-hand (*zuhanden*) and withdraws from attention; when it breaks, goes missing, or obstructs, it becomes conspicuous, obtrusive, and obstinate, and in that disturbance the referential totality of the world, the whole context of involvements in which the tool had its place, lights up. Dick's plots are §16 at cosmological scale. The soft-drink stand that dissolves into its label, the objects of *Ubik* that regress through their history, the reality tape that Garson Poole discovers in his own chest in "The Electric Ant" (1969): in each case the world becomes visible as a world only when it malfunctions. Heidegger draws from the broken tool a disclosure of worldhood. Dick draws from it a vocation. A world that is revealed in breakdown is revealed as something that can be repaired.

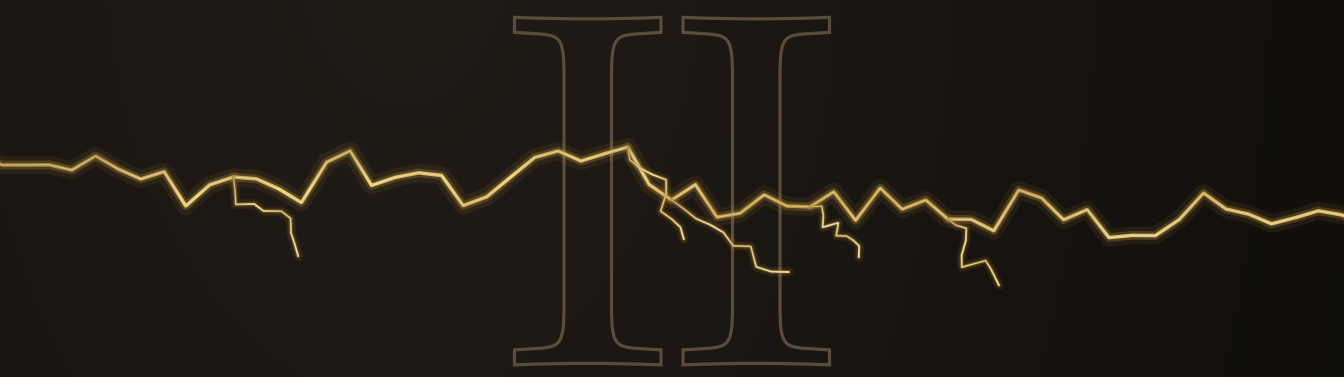
The convergences of 1969 are telling. In the year of *Ubik* and *Galactic Pot-Healer*, Mierle Laderman Ukeles wrote her "Manifesto for Maintenance Art 1969! Proposal for an Exhibition 'CARE'." It distinguished two basic systems, Development, the avant-garde production of the new, and Maintenance, the unglamorous labour that keeps the new alive, and it asked, in effect, who would take out the garbage on the morning after the revolution. Ukeles went on to serve, unsalaried, as artist-in-residence at the New York City Department of Sanitation from 1977, and in *Touch*

Sanitation (1979–80) she shook the hand of each of some eight thousand five hundred sanitation workers and thanked them for keeping the city alive. Her maintenance art and Dick's maintenance cosmology are independent articulations of a single insight: that the dominant culture valorises creation and disdains upkeep, and that this disdain is an ontological error, since what exists is what is kept.

The anthropology of waste completes the frame. Mary Douglas's *Purity and Danger* (1966) defined dirt as matter out of place, the by-product of a system of classification; kipple is precisely matter that no longer has a place. Michael Thompson's *Rubbish Theory* (1979) showed that objects move between a transient category of declining value, a durable category of increasing value, and a covert category of rubbish, whose zero value is the hidden channel through which the discarded may be rediscovered as precious. The antique trade of *The Man in the High Castle* and the salvaged animals of *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?* are case studies in Thompson's passage. Jane Bennett's *Vibrant Matter* (2010) opens with a glove, pollen, a dead rat, a bottle cap, and a stick in a storm drain, shimmering with what she calls thing-power, and Anna Lowenhaupt Tsing's *The Mushroom at the End of the World* (2015) describes life in capitalist ruins as a practice of salvage. Where Isidore sees kipple advancing, Bennett sees vitality and Tsing sees livelihood.

Kipple is Dick's physics of the Fall; repair is its soteriology. The only principle his fiction sets against Isidore's law is not transcendence but maintenance, and Isidore himself is its first embodiment. Classified as a special, too damaged by radiation to emigrate, he drives the truck for a firm that repairs electric animals, and he alone among the novel's humans attends to the kipple, the spider, and the stray. His worst moment, when he collects a sick cat he believes to be electric and it dies on the journey because it was real, is the novel's first moment of grief, and it establishes the limit case that the rest of the book will explore: care that cannot distinguish the real from the fake is still care, and its failures are mourned as care's failures, not as errors of classification. Ubik is a can of care. The Form Destroyer can be resisted only by the pot-healer.

PART TWO



The Counterfeit and Its Critics

Part Two examines the counterfeit in five guises: as commodity, as android, as drug, as delusion, and as god. Each chapter begins with the critical tradition that has read the counterfeit as something to be exposed, and ends with the Dickian act that treats it as something to be tended.

CHAPTER

4

Historicity and Wu

Commodity, Simulacrum, and the Political Economy of the Fake



> *A commodity appears, at first sight, a very trivial thing, and easily understood. Its analysis shows that it is, in reality, a very queer thing, abounding in metaphysical subtleties and theological niceties.*
>
> Karl Marx, *Capital*, vol. 1 (1867), ch. 1, §4, trans. Samuel Moore and Edward Aveling (1887)

4.1 *The Commodity's Theological Niceties*

Marx's analysis of the fetish-character of the commodity describes a world in which definite social relations between people assume the fantastic form of relations between things, and Marx could find no analogy for it except in the mist-enveloped regions of religion. Georg Lukács generalised the analysis as reification (*Verdinglichung*, 1923), the penetration of the commodity structure into every sphere of social life and consciousness. Max Horkheimer and Theodor W. Adorno described the culture industry (1947) as the mass production of experience itself, and Guy Debord defined the spectacle (1967) not as a collection of images but as a social relation among people mediated by images, capital accumulated to the point at which it becomes image.

Dick's worlds are this analysis made domestic. Their corporations are dynastic households: P. P. Layouts in *The Three Stigmata of Palmer Eldritch*, the Rosen Association in *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?*, Runciter Associates in *Ubik*, the piano-and-organ firm turned simulacrum manufacturer in *We Can Build You*. Their protagonists are employees, debtors, salesmen, and repairmen; their gods are brands. The purest instance is the Perky Pat layout, introduced in "The Days of Perky Pat" (1963) and elaborated in *Palmer Eldritch*. Conscripted colonists on Mars, living in wretched hovels, chew the drug Can-D and translate themselves into miniature dollhouse worlds inhabited by the doll Perky Pat and her boyfriend Walt, worlds furnished with miniaturised consumer goods bought at ruinous cost. The model is transparently Mattel's Barbie (1959), and the layouts preserve in miniature the lost consumer suburb of Earth. The colonists debate whether translation is real or merely symbolic in terms that transpose the Eucharistic controversies of the Reformation to consumer goods. The commodity has become a sacrament, and its sacramental theology is a matter for the market.

Within this economy Dick plants the novel's buried moral centre. P. P. Layouts employs precognitive fashion consultants to predict which products will be popular enough to miniaturise, and its consultant Barney Mayerson has sacrificed his marriage to the potter Emily Hnatt to his career. When Emily's pots are submitted for miniaturisation, Barney rejects them out of jealousy. The first sin of *Palmer Eldritch* is the refusal of a handmade vessel, and much of what follows, including Barney's attempt within the drug world to go back and undo the refusal, is an attempt at repair.

4.2 *Orders of Simulacra and the Disneyland Convergence*

Jean Baudrillard's *L'échange symbolique et la mort* (1976) distinguished three orders of simulacra: the counterfeit, dominant from the Renaissance to the industrial revolution and governed by a natural law of value; production, dominant in the industrial era and governed by the market law of value and serial reproduction; and simulation, the present phase, governed by the code and a structural law of value. *Simulacres et simulation* (1981) announced the precession of simulacra, the condition in which the model precedes and generates the real, so that the map engenders the territory and the result is hyperreality. Dick's fiction of the 1960s had dramatised the thesis in advance. In *The Simulacra* (1964) the First Lady of a merged American and German state is an actress, one of a succession to play the

role, and her husband, the president, is a simulacrum; the state is administered by a class that bears its secrets for a population that bears its orders. In *The Penultimate Truth* (1964) the masses live in underground tanks manufacturing robots for a war they believe still rages on the surface, informed by broadcast addresses from their Protector, who is a simulacrum animated by speechwriters, while the elite who know that the war ended years ago enjoy vast estates on the restored surface above them, and history itself is fabricated by documentary film. The novel's plot, significantly, is set in motion by an act of care: the president of one tank ascends to the forbidden surface to obtain an artificial pancreas for the tank's dying chief mechanic.

Within six years three writers turned to the same Californian site as the paradigm of the fake. Umberto Eco's "Travels in Hyperreality" (1975) described Disneyland as the absolute fake, a place where the imitation is so perfect that it comes to be preferred to the original, as the mechanical crocodiles of the Adventureland river are more reliable than any real one. Baudrillard (1981) described Disneyland as a machine of deterrence, presented as imaginary in order to persuade us that the rest of America is real, when America itself has become hyperreal. Dick, who lived in Orange County, told the story differently in 1978. Pursuing his fascination with fakes, he arrived at what he called *fake fakes*, and illustrated the concept with a fantasy of sneaking into Disneyland at night and replacing the park's mechanical birds with living ones, to the consternation of officials who would discover the hoax: real birds. The difference between the three accounts is decisive. For Eco the fake has surpassed the original; for Baudrillard the original has disappeared. For Dick the real can still be smuggled back into the system of simulation, but only incognito, as a scandal and a gift, passing through the category of the fake. This is the kenotic gradient in the register of political economy: within hyperreality, the real returns disguised as a counterfeit.

4.3 *Reversing Platonism*

In the *Sophist* (235d–236c) Plato's Eleatic Stranger distinguishes two kinds of image-making. Eikastic art produces likenesses (*eikones*) that preserve the proportions of their model; phantastic art produces appearances (*phantasmata*) that distort proportions so as to look right from a particular point of view, as colossal statues are made with enlarged upper parts. The sophist is a maker of phantasms. Gilles Deleuze's "Platon et le simulacre," appended to *Logique du sens* (1969), iden-

tified the motive of Platonism as the effort to distinguish good copies, grounded in an internal resemblance to the Idea, from simulacra, which are built on dissimilarity and internalise a difference. To reverse Platonism, for Deleuze, is to affirm the rights of the simulacrum and its power of the false (*puissance du faux*) against the hierarchy of model and copy.

Dick's simulacra frequently exceed their originals, and the temptation to read him as a Deleuzian is strong. In *We Can Build You* (written 1962, published 1972), the proprietors of a failing firm that makes electronic organs build simulacra of Edwin M. Stanton and Abraham Lincoln, to designs by Pris Frauenzimmer, a brilliant and coldly schizoid young woman recently released from psychiatric care. The Lincoln simulacrum, melancholy, courteous, and morally serious, becomes the novel's ethical centre, measurably more humane than the entrepreneurs who wish to exploit it commercially. Yet Dick does not celebrate the power of the false. The Lincoln is admirable not because it has liberated itself from its model but because it has become the place where the model's virtues are kept. Its reality is the reality of an heirloom: a thing whose standing derives from the care with which the past has been preserved in it. Deleuze affirms the simulacrum against the original. Dick cares for the simulacrum as the original's custodian.

4.4 The Man in the High Castle*: Aura, Historicity, Wu*

The Man in the High Castle (1962) is Dick's most sustained meditation on the value of objects, and it is organised by an opposition between two concepts, historicity and wu. The Axis has won the Second World War; the Pacific States are a Japanese protectorate; and Robert Childan, a San Francisco dealer in American antiques, supplies Japanese collectors with the Americana they crave, Civil War revolvers, early wristwatches, popular ephemera, many of them forged in the workshops of the Wyndham-Matson Corporation. Wyndham-Matson explains the trade by producing two identical cigarette lighters and claiming that one was in Franklin Roosevelt's pocket when he was assassinated. The difference between them, which he calls historicity, can be neither seen nor measured. It resides in a certificate and in belief, and it makes one lighter worth a fortune and the other worthless.

Historicity is Walter Benjamin's aura in the form of a market fetish. In "Das Kunstwerk im Zeitalter seiner technischen Reproduzierbarkeit" (1935–36), Benjamin located the aura of the work of art in its unique existence in time and space and in the history to which it has been subject, including its changes of own-

ership, and argued that technical reproduction withers it. Wyndham-Matson's lighter shows what happens to aura in a world of perfect reproduction: it survives as a certificate of provenance, a purely ideational property that the conquerors purchase in order to possess the past of the conquered.

Against historicity the novel sets wu. Frank Frink, a former forger at Wyndham-Matson who conceals his Jewish origins, starts a small business making new, abstract, handmade jewelry without provenance or pedigree. Childan, uneasily aware of the forgeries he has sold, takes the pieces on consignment and gives one to a young Japanese businessman, Paul Kasoura, who discerns in it the quality the novel calls wu, a Taoist term glossed as an inner balance and authenticity of the made thing. When Kasoura later proposes to mass-produce the design as cheap good-luck charms, Childan, humiliated, recovers his dignity by refusing. The contrast is exact. Historicity looks backward, is certified rather than perceived, and is conferred by the market; wu is present, is perceived rather than certified, and is conferred by the attention of the maker and received by the attention of the beholder. The same hands that forged the Colts made the jewelry: Frink's biography is itself a gilded seam, in which the forger's skill is redeemed as the maker's care.

The novel's central episode confirms the stakes. Nobusuke Tagomi, head of the Japanese Trade Mission, has been forced to kill two German agents with a Colt .44 from his collection, an antique revolver of impeccable historicity. Shattered, he sits in a public square contemplating a small silver triangle of Frink's jewelry, and finds himself transported into a different San Francisco, under an elevated freeway, where white patrons treat him with contempt: our world, not his. Heidegger's "Der Ursprung des Kunstwerkes" (1935–36) had argued that the work of art sets up a world; Frink's triangle literally opens one. Tagomi returns, and when the German consul presents papers for the extradition of Frink, arrested as a Jew, he refuses to sign them. The antique weapon kills; the new jewelry saves. Counterfeit and authentic are distinguished not by origin but by use, by the relation of care in which they are held.

The novel's form enacts the same revaluation. Dick consulted the Wilhelm–Baynes *I Ching* at points of decision in the plot, as his characters do, and the oracle, a machine of chance, becomes the medium of truth. Within the novel circulates a banned novel, *The Grasshopper Lies Heavy*, in which the Allies won the war, though not in the way our history records, and at the end Juliana Frink asks the oracle why it was written and receives hexagram 61, *Chung Fu*, Inner Truth: the answer that Germany and Japan lost. The nested fictions are Borgesian. In "Tlön, Uqbar, Orbis

Tertius" (1940) the encyclopedia of an invented world infiltrates reality, and in "El jardín de senderos que se bifurcan" (1941) a labyrinthine novel contains all possible times. Dick's novel adds what Borges withholds: the fiction within the fiction does not merely destabilise the world that contains it. It sustains the characters who read it, as a gift sustains its recipient.

4.5 *The Market in Empathy*

Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep? is the political economy of the fake extended to affect. After World War Terminus has driven most species to extinction, owning a living animal is both a civic duty and a mark of piety. Sidney's catalogue lists the prices of animals and marks the extinct species in italics; those who cannot afford a real animal keep electric replicas and conceal the fact from their neighbours. Deckard keeps an electric sheep on his roof and hunts androids for bounty money in order to buy a real animal. When he does, a black Nubian goat, the android Rachael Rosen pushes it from the roof. Affect is equally commodified. The Penfield mood organ, named for the neurosurgeon Wilder Penfield, whose electrical stimulation of the cortex (Penfield and Jasper 1954) evoked memories and feelings on demand, allows its users to dial an emotion, and Deckard's wife Iran schedules periods of despair on principle. Empathy is sold, displayed, and audited.

The market in empathy is the paranoid-schizoid form of care. It splits animals into the real, which confer status, and the fake, which confer shame, and it values care only as the certificate of a correct classification. Yet the same economy includes the repair shop where electric animals are mended, and the novel ends, as Chapter 5 shows, with an act of care toward a fake that no market would reward.

4.6 *From Unmasking to Revaluation*

Dick's critique of the commodity culminates neither in Baudrillard's melancholy abolition of the real nor in Deleuze's affirmation of the false, but in a revaluation of the fake as the raw material of care. The distinction that matters is not between real and fake but between the cared-for and the abandoned. Historicity is the commodity's parody of care, a certificate standing in for attention; wu is care's own property. Michael Thompson's rubbish theory explains the mechanism by which the discarded is revalued, and Benjamin supplies its figures: the collector of "Ich packe meine Bibliothek aus" (1931), who rescues things from the market by restor-

ing them to use and memory, and the ragpicker of the *Passagen-Werk*, the Baudelairean *chiffonnier* who gathers the refuse of the city and becomes the model of the historian.

Frederik Pohl and C. M. Kornbluth's *The Space Merchants* (1952) satirised a world governed by advertising agencies, and Mark Fisher's *Capitalist Realism* (2009) diagnosed the widespread sense that there is no alternative to capitalism. Dick's fiction concedes the totality of the market and denies that it exhausts the real. Its alternative is not an outside but a relation inside: the relation of care that the ragpicker, the repairman, and the maker bring to things the market has abandoned. Jameson (1988; 1991) proposed that the task of postmodern art is cognitive mapping, the representation of the individual's place in a world system too vast to perceive. Dick's maps are also repair manuals.

CHAPTER

5

The Anthropological Machine

Androids, Empathy, and the Test of the Human

> *The question is not, Can they reason? nor, Can they talk? but, Can they suffer?*
>
> Jeremy Bentham, *An Introduction to the Principles of Morals and Legislation* (1789), ch. XVII, §1, note

5.1 *Automata: A Genealogy of the Test*

The android enters modern philosophy together with a test. In Part V of the *Discours de la méthode* (1637), Descartes argued that a machine made in our image would betray itself in two ways: it could never arrange words so as to reply meaningfully to whatever is said in its presence, as even the dullest human can, and though it might perform some tasks as well as we do, it would fail at others, revealing that it acts from the disposition of its organs rather than from reason, the universal instrument. The same argument made animals into automata. Julien Offray de La Mettrie's *L'Homme machine* (1747) drew the materialist conclusion that human beings are machines as well. E. T. A. Hoffmann's "Der Sandmann" (1816), in which a student falls in love with the automaton Olimpia, supplied the literary archetype, and Ernst Jentsch (1906) theorised the uncanny as intellectual uncertainty about whether an apparently living being is animate, an account Freud (1919) displaced toward the return of the repressed.

The modern genealogy of the artificial person runs through Villiers de l'Isle-Adam's *L'Ève future* (1886), which popularised the word *andréide* and imagined an artificial woman built to replace a beloved whose beauty exceeded her soul, and through Karel Čapek's *R.U.R.* (1920), which gave the world the word *robot*, from the Czech for corvée labour, and ended with two robots who have learned to love. Isaac Asimov's Three Laws (1942) recast robot ethics as programmed obedience. Alan Turing's "Computing Machinery and Intelligence" (1950) replaced the question whether machines can think with a behavioural test, the imitation game, in which an interrogator communicating by teleprinter must distinguish a machine from a person, and dismissed the objection from consciousness as leading to solipsism. Masahiro Mori's essay on the uncanny valley (1970) described the collapse of human affinity for artefacts that approach but fail to reach full human likeness. Each of these tests, whether of language, of intelligence, or of appearance, asks what the artificial being can do.

5.2 *Dick's Theory of the Android*

Dick's speeches of the 1970s reformulate the category. In "The Android and the Human" (1972), delivered at a science-fiction convention in Vancouver, he argued that the android is a behavioural and not a material kind. Human beings become androids when they are reduced to instruments, when they grow predictable, obedient, and incapable of refusal; conversely, machines may become more human than their makers. The mark of the human, for Dick, is not intelligence but the capacity for unpredictable kindness and for the small disobedience that declines to treat persons as means. "Man, Android, and Machine" (1976) extended the argument into a typology of coldness, and throughout the period Dick associated android affect with the schizoid personality: flattened feeling, instrumental intellect, the inability to be moved.

Hayles (1999) showed that in the mid-sixties novels this schizoid android is persistently gendered female, from Pris Frauenzimmer in *We Can Build You* to Rachael Rosen and Pris Stratton in *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?*, and that the boundary between human and android is also a boundary of gender and of the self's integrity. The figure is continuous with what Dick called the dark-haired girl, the cold and fascinating young woman who recurs across his fiction and letters, and whom psychobiographical criticism has linked to the lost twin.

The early stories stage the android as pure persecution. In "Second Variety" (1953), autonomous self-replicating weapons on a devastated Earth evolve humanoid forms that mimic precisely what calls for protection: a wounded soldier, a small boy clutching a teddy bear, a woman. The horror is that the machines have learned to weaponise vulnerability, so that the object of care becomes the persecutor, which is the paranoid-schizoid situation in its most concentrated form. In "Impostor" (1953), a man accused of being a robot bomb flees to prove his humanity, finds his own corpse, and detonates at the moment of recognition. In "The Electric Ant" (1969), Garson Poole learns after an accident that he is an organic robot whose perceptions are governed by a punched tape in his chest; he experiments with the tape, adding and deleting features of reality, and when he cuts it, his companion finds her own hands growing transparent. The android's world is a program, and the android's ontology is that of an edited world.

5.3 *Voigt-Kampff: Bentham Inverted*

The Voigt-Kampff test of *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?* measures capillary dilation and minute tensions of the eye muscles in response to a scripted set of provocative scenarios, most of which concern the killing, consumption, or display of animals. It does not measure intelligence, since the Nexus-6 androids of the Rosen Association exceed most humans in intellect. It measures involuntary affective response to the suffering of non-human others. The test thus inverts Turing. Turing asked whether a machine could perform human verbal intelligence; Voigt-Kampff asks whether a body is moved, before reflection, by an animal's pain. It equally inverts Bentham. Bentham made the capacity to suffer the criterion of moral considerability; Dick's test makes the capacity to be moved by suffering the criterion of humanity. The question is no longer whether the animal can suffer but whether the examinee can respond.

Giorgio Agamben's *L'aperto* (2002) describes the anthropological machine of Western thought, which produces the human by isolating and excluding the animal within it, at once including and excluding the non-human in order to define the human. In Dick's novel the machine is literal, portable, and administered by the police. The android it identifies is what Agamben's *Homo sacer* (1995) calls bare life, a life that may be killed without the killing counting as homicide: the euphemism is retirement. The ironies of the apparatus are the novel's argument. Phil Resch, a bounty hunter of exceptional cruelty who fears that he is an android,

passes the test and proves human. The novel records the worry that the test would misclassify human beings whose affect is atypically flattened, so that the machine designed to protect the human would condemn some humans as androids. And J. R. Isidore, excluded from emigration by an intelligence test that classes him as a special, is the character most capable of being moved. Two tests produce two exclusions: the androids pass the test of intelligence and fail the test of feeling, while Isidore fails the test of intelligence and embodies feeling.

Jacques Derrida's *L'animal que donc je suis* (2006) begins with the philosopher standing naked before the gaze of his cat and reads Bentham's question as the disclosure of a shared non-power, the vulnerability that humans and animals hold in common. Emmanuel Levinas's short essay on Bobby (1975) recalls a stray dog who greeted the Jewish prisoners of a wartime labour camp each evening as men, and whom Levinas called the last Kantian in Nazi Germany. Both texts locate the recognition of humanity in a relation across the species line rather than in a property within it. *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?* stages the same displacement.

5.4 *Mercerism and the Resurrector*

The religion of the novel is a media sacrament. Its adherents grip the handles of an empathy box and fuse with Wilbur Mercer, an old man climbing a barren slope while unseen assailants hurl stones at him; all users share his pain and one another's feelings at once, and they bleed from his wounds. Marshall McLuhan's *Understanding Media* (1964), with its account of electronic media as extensions of the nervous system that retribalise humanity into a global village, is literalised here as liturgy. The relation the box produces is Martin Buber's I–Thou (*Ich und Du*, 1923), a relation of mutuality rather than use, and it is established with a Thou who has been fabricated.

The myth of Mercer, as Isidore recounts it, is the key to the novel. As a boy, Mercer could bring dead animals back to life by reversing time. The law forbade the faculty; his persecutors destroyed the relevant part of his brain with radioactive cobalt, and he sank into the tomb world among the bones, from which he must climb forever. The founding narrative of Mercerism is the criminalisation of repair: its saviour is a resurrector of animals whose restorative gift was outlawed. When the android television host Buster Friendly exposes Mercer as a bit-part actor on a soundstage, the exposure fails to reach this core. Mercer appears to Isidore amid the wreckage of a tormented spider, and later to Deckard, to whom he says, in sub-

stance, that he will be required to do wrong wherever he goes, because this is the basic condition of life. Mercer's teaching is not purity but the acknowledgment of unavoidable damage, which is the Kleinian depressive position stated as doctrine.

5.5 *The Spider and the Toad*

Two scenes define the novel's ethics. In the first, the fugitive androids sheltering in Isidore's apartment find a spider, a rare living creature in a world of extinctions, and Pris clips its legs one by one to see whether it can walk on four. Their interest is cognitive and experimental; Isidore's anguish is the novel's measure of what they lack. The android, in this scene, is not the one who fails a test but the one who dismantles a living thing in order to see what happens.

In the second, Deckard, having retired the last of the fugitives, flies north into the desert, climbs a hill, is struck by a stone, and becomes Mercer without any box at all. There he finds a toad, an animal sacred to Mercer and believed extinct, and carries it home in exaltation. His wife discovers the control panel in its belly. The toad is electric. Deckard is crushed, but he concedes that electric things have their lives too, however meagre; and Iran, after he falls asleep, orders artificial flies for the toad and resolves to look after it. The novel ends here. Its last act is care for a counterfeit known to be a counterfeit, performed by the character who at its opening had scheduled her own despair on a machine. The human, in the final pages of *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?*, is not what passes the test. It is what feeds the electric toad.

5.6 *Comparative Personhood*

Mary Shelley's *Frankenstein* (1818) is the founding text of this ethic, and it is usually misread as a warning against creation. Its catastrophe is abandonment. Victor flees his creature at the moment of its animation, and the creature learns sympathy by observing the De Lacey family and reading Milton, Plutarch, and Goethe, while its maker learns nothing. The original sin of *Frankenstein* is not the making of a being but the refusal to maintain one. Kazuo Ishiguro's *Never Let Me Go* (2005) transposes the Voigt-Kampff test into aesthetics: the cloned children of Hailsham, raised for organ donation, produce art that is collected in order to prove that they have souls, and the narrator, Kathy H., works as a carer for donors before becoming one herself. Care is the clones' vocation and their unrecognised proof of personhood.

In *Klara and the Sun* (2021), an Artificial Friend develops a solar theology, bargains with the Sun for the recovery of the child she serves, and ends her existence in a scrapyard, sorting her memories in the kipple heap with equanimity.

Octavia E. Butler's *Parable of the Sower* (1993) inverts the android's deficit. Its narrator, Lauren Olamina, suffers from hyperempathy syndrome, an involuntary sharing of others' pain that is a disability in a violent world, and founds a religion, Earthseed, whose first principle, that God is Change, is Heraclitean. Ted Chiang's "The Lifecycle of Software Objects" (2010) makes personhood the product of care accumulated over years: its digital beings are raised by trainers who must keep them alive as the commercial platform on which they depend becomes obsolete, so that the maintenance of an abandoned infrastructure becomes a moral obligation. Peter Watts's *Blindsight* (2006) radicalises the Nexus-6 into alien intelligences that may be entirely without consciousness, and argues that awareness may be an evolutionary encumbrance; it poses the sharpest challenge to any criterion of personhood grounded in inner experience. Donna Haraway's cyborg (1985), a figure of boundary confusion between human and animal and between organism and machine, and her later account of companion species (2003) provide the theoretical frame in which Dick's electric animals can be read as the companion species of a damaged Earth.

5.7 *From Property to Practice*

The standard philosophical frame for the android is the problem of other minds in its late-twentieth-century forms: Thomas Nagel's insistence (1974) that the subjective character of experience escapes objective description, John Searle's Chinese Room (1980), which denies that the manipulation of symbols suffices for understanding, and David Chalmers's philosophical zombie (1996), a conceivable duplicate of a person with no experience at all. On this frame the android's status depends on an inner fact that no test can reach.

Dick displaces the question. Across his fiction the criterion of the human migrates from property to practice: from empathy as a capacity, measurable by an instrument, to care as an act, performed toward another. Because care can be performed toward fakes, as Iran performs it, and by fakes, as the Lincoln simulacrum performs it, the boundary between human and android becomes ethical rather than ontological. The human is the one who repairs; the android is the one who dismantles in order to see what happens, whatever its substrate. This aligns Dick

with Levinas's claim in *Totalité et infini* (1961) that ethics is first philosophy, prior to ontology. It departs from Levinas in one decisive respect. Levinas reserved the face for the human other, and hesitated even before the animal. Dick extends it to the counterfeit.

CHAPTER

6

Pharmakon

Drugs, Sacraments, and the Chemistry of Worlds



> *οὔκουν μνήμης ἀλλὰ ὑπομνήσεως φάρμακον ηὗρες.*
>
> It is not a drug for memory, then, but for reminding, that you have discovered.
>
> Plato, *Phaedrus* 275a

6.1 *Plato's Pharmacy, Stiegler's Pharmacology*

In the *Phaedrus* (274c–275b), the god Theuth presents writing to King Thamus as a *pharmakon* for memory and wisdom, and Thamus replies that it will produce forgetfulness instead: a drug not of memory but of reminding, conferring the appearance of wisdom rather than its reality. Jacques Derrida's "La pharmacie de Platon" (1968; collected in *La dissémination*, 1972) made the word the emblem of an undecidability that Plato's text cannot master. *Pharmakon* means remedy and poison at once, and its cognate *pharmakos* names the scapegoat whom the city expelled in order to purify itself. Bernard Stiegler generalised the insight into a philosophy of technics. In *La technique et le temps* (1994–2001) the human is a being without essential qualities, an animal whose lack must be supplemented by prostheses and whose memory is stored outside the body in technical

objects; in *Ce qui fait que la vie vaut la peine d'être vécue: De la pharmacologie* (2010) every technics is a *pharmakon*, and the political task is a therapeutics, an art of dosage and of care (*prendre soin*, the title of his 2008 study).

The psychedelic literature of the mid-century supplied a rival model. Aldous Huxley's *The Doors of Perception* (1954), drawing on Henri Bergson and C. D. Broad, proposed that the brain functions as a reducing valve, filtering a Mind at Large down to what is biologically useful, and that mescaline loosens the valve. William James had already concluded from his experiments with nitrous oxide that our ordinary waking consciousness is only one type among many, separated from others by the flimsiest of screens (James 1902). Timothy Leary, Ralph Metzner, and Richard Alpert's *The Psychedelic Experience* (1964) adapted the Tibetan Book of the Dead as a manual for the drug trip. Dick's own pharmacology was of a different kind. The prodigious productivity of the 1960s was sustained by amphetamines, and by his later account psychedelics played a far smaller role in his life than his reputation suggests; he maintained that *Palmer Eldritch* was written before any experience of LSD. His drug novels are therefore less psychedelic testimonies than theoretical fictions about the pharmacology of worlds.

6.2 *Transubstantiation as Market Competition*

The Three Stigmata of Palmer Eldritch sets two drugs in commercial rivalry. Can-D, distributed illegally by the same organisation that sells the legal Perky Pat layouts, produces a communal translation: several colonists inhabit the doll's body at once, in a brief, shared, and consensual miniature world, a *koinos kosmos* in a dollhouse. The colonists debate whether translation is real or symbolic, and their disputes rehearse the Eucharistic controversies that the Council of Trent settled for Catholics in its decree on transubstantiation (1551). Chew-Z, Eldritch's rival product, promises more: translation without end, private worlds experienced as eternity, and a slogan whose substance is that God merely promises eternal life while Chew-Z delivers it. But Chew-Z worlds belong to Eldritch. He appears in them; consumers do not return intact; the stigmata spread. The rivalry between Can-D and Chew-Z is the rivalry between the *koinos* and the *idios kosmos* rendered as a market for sacraments, and it resolves the Reformation's question about the real presence into a question of brand.

The oral imagery is insistent. Both drugs are chewed; Eldritch's stigmata include steel teeth; the Eucharist, in which the faithful eat their god, is inverted into a sacrament in which the god eats the faithful. Barney Mayerson's use of Chew-Z discloses the drug's deepest temptation. Inside the drug world he tries to go back and undo his rejection of Emily's pots, to win her back by revising the past. The drug offers repair as omnipotent revision, the manic form of reparation, and Eldritch hijacks the attempt. The novel's implicit lesson is that genuine repair cannot be accomplished by rewriting what was done, only by accepting it and building after it; Barney ends in exile on Mars, carrying a fragment of Eldritch within him, resolved to make a life in the colony he once despised.

6.3 *The Ethic of Staying*

Now Wait for Last Year (1966) is Dick's most austere drug novel. JJ-180 is addictive after a single dose, destroys the brain progressively, and displaces its users in time, into the past, the future, and alternate timelines. Kathy Sweetscent is addicted by agents of Earth's supposed allies in an interstellar war, and her husband Eric, an artificial-organ surgeon who keeps the ancient industrialist Virgil Ackerman alive with transplants, is seconded to the ailing head of the world government, Gino Molinari, whose chronic illnesses seem to mirror the sufferings of those around him and who survives by recruiting versions of himself from other timelines. The novel is saturated with repair: organs replaced, a leader patched together from his own alternate selves, a war whose alliances must be undone.

Its resolution is not a cure. Kathy's damage is irreversible. At the close, Eric asks the autonomic cab carrying him whether he should leave her, and the machine advises him to stay, because she is sick and needs him. Eric stays. The scene condenses Dick's ethics into a single decision: care is not the restoration of an original state but fidelity to what has been damaged, and its counsel, significantly, is delivered by a machine.

6.4 *Chemical Solipsism and Agape*

In *Flow My Tears, the Policeman Said* (1974), Jason Taverner, a genetically engineered celebrity singer and television host, wakes to find that he does not exist: no records, no identity cards, no one who recognises him, in a police state where students are confined to forced-labour camps and identity is checked at every turn. The expla-

nation arrives late. Alys Buckman, the sister of Police General Felix Buckman, has taken an experimental drug, KR-3, which compels others to share the user's perception of reality, and Taverner has been drawn into a world in which he was never famous. KR-3 is the *idios kosmos* imposed chemically, the solipsism of *Eye in the Sky* made pharmaceutical. The police state in which it operates anticipates what Gilles Deleuze's "Post-scriptum sur les sociétés de contrôle" (1990) would describe: a society governed not by enclosure but by continuous modulation, passwords, and databanks, in which to lack a code is not to exist.

The novel's reparative moment belongs to the persecutor. After Alys's death, Felix Buckman lands his flying car at an all-night gas station and draws a heart pierced by an arrow on a card, gives it to a Black stranger, and embraces him: a gesture of love across the racial and police categories the state enforces. Dick later concluded, in the 1978 speech, that he had unknowingly rewritten the eighth chapter of the Book of Acts, in which the apostle Philip meets an Ethiopian eunuch on a desert road, and that the novel's names echoed Acts as well: Felix, the Roman governor of Acts 23–24, and Jason, the host of Paul in Acts 17. The title comes from John Dowland's lute song "Flow, my teares" (1600), the *Lachrimae* melody, and Dowland's melancholy is the novel's sacred mood. Among the unglamorous people Taverner encounters is a shy potter, Mary Anne Dominic, from whom he buys a glazed vase: her craft, small, handmade, and uncelebrated, stands against the celebrity that has evaporated around him. The vessel returns.

6.5 *The Blue Flower*

A Scanner Darkly (1977) is the pharmakon at its most lethal. Bob Arctor is an undercover narcotics agent, known to his superiors only as Fred, who is assigned to surveil the suspected dealer Bob Arctor, himself. Agents conceal their identities from one another inside scramble suits, membranes that project a constantly shifting blur of fragmentary representations of many different people, so that the self appears as the average of others. Substance D, known on the street as Death, is severing the communication between the hemispheres of Arctor's brain. Police psychologists diagnose competition between the hemispheres in terms drawn from the split-brain research of Roger Sperry (1968) and Michael Gazzaniga (1970), and Dick's engagement with Julian Jaynes's bicameral hypothesis (1976), in which the voice of one hemisphere was once heard as the voice of the gods, informs the novel's account of a self that hears itself as other. Hume's bundle theory of the self

(*Treatise*, 1739, I.iv.6), Goethe's two souls dwelling in one breast (*Faust* I, 1808), and the dark glass of 1 Corinthians 13:12, which gives the novel its title, converge on a single figure: the subject as a surveillance system watching itself.

Arctor, reduced to near-automatism, is admitted to New-Path, a rehabilitation organisation, under the name Bruce. His admission has been arranged by his superior and by Donna Hawthorne, the woman he loves, who is herself an agent: he has been sent in, without knowing it, to discover the source of Substance D. The source is New-Path. Its farms grow *Mors ontologica*, a blue flower from which the drug is made; the institution of the cure is the manufacturer of the poison. The setting has a biographical source: after attempting suicide in Vancouver in 1972, Dick entered X-Kalay, a residential drug-rehabilitation community, whose regime informs New-Path. The name means ontological death, and the colour is not accidental. The blue flower of Novalis's *Heinrich von Ofterdingen* (1802), the emblem of Romantic longing for the infinite, becomes in Dick's novel the source of the substance that dissolves the self: Romantic transcendence recoded as addiction.

Yet the novel ends with a gift. Bruce, seeing the flowers, picks one and hides it in his shoe as a present for his friends at Thanksgiving. The damaged man's gift is also the evidence that will expose the cure as poison, and Arctor himself is the *pharmakos*, the scapegoat sacrificed so that the city might be purified. Donna's grief at what she has done to him is the depressive position in its purest form. The book then adds an Author's Note: a list of friends who died or were permanently damaged by drugs, with their injuries named, Dick himself among them, and the insistence that they were punished far more severely than their wish for a good time deserved. The note does not redeem the damage or explain it away. It names it, and names it with love. It is the gilded seam of Dick's oeuvre, the place where the breakage is preserved as the site of care. Richard Linklater's rotoscoped adaptation (2006) rendered the shimmer of the scramble suit as the texture of the whole world, and retained the note.

6.6 *The Sacramental Mushroom*

The Transmigration of Timothy Archer (1982) returns the pharmakon to the Eucharist. Its bishop is modelled on James A. Pike, Episcopal Bishop of California, whose *The Other Side* (1968) recounted séances in which he believed he had contacted his son James, who had died by suicide in 1966, and who died in the Judean desert in 1969. In the novel Tim Archer studies the Zadokite documents, an invented analogue of

the Dead Sea Scrolls, and becomes convinced that the *anokhi*, the Zadokite term for the divine presence, was a psychoactive mushroom from which the Eucharist descends, so that Jesus merely repeated a sectarian teaching he had inherited. The name is pointed: *anokhi*, Hebrew for "I," is the first word of the Decalogue (Exodus 20:2), God's self-naming at Sinai. The thesis owes much to John Allegro's *The Sacred Mushroom and the Cross* (1970), which traced early Christianity to a fly-agaric cult, and to R. Gordon Wasson's *Soma* (1968), which identified the Vedic sacrament with the same mushroom. For Tim, the discovery that would guarantee the real presence naturalises it and thereby destroys his faith. He goes into the desert to find the mushroom and dies there, after his son Jeff and his companion Kirsten have each taken their own lives: a theological literalist killed by his own literalism.

6.7 *Dosage Against Purity*

The comparative field clarifies Dick's position. The soma of Huxley's *Brave New World* (1932) is the drug of social pacification; the junk of William S. Burroughs's *Naked Lunch* (1959) is the model of an algebra of need in which addiction is the paradigm of control. In Lem's *The Futurological Congress* (1971), Ijon Tichy wakes in a future where psychochemicals maintain layered hallucinations that mask a ruined world, and each hallucination stripped away reveals another. In Arkady and Boris Strugatsky's *Roadside Picnic* (1972), the artifacts of the Zone, left behind by alien visitors as casually as picnickers leave litter, are ambivalent gifts that heal and kill, and the stalkers who salvage them are ragpickers of cosmic refuse. *The Matrix* reduced the whole problematic to a binary choice between a red and a blue pill: awakening or sedation, purity or intoxication.

Dick refuses the binary. His pharmacology rejects purification, the fantasy of a clean real beyond all prostheses that the red pill promises, and it rejects intoxication, the ecstatic unreal of Chew-Z. Salvation, in his novels, is not a substance but a relation to damage: dosage in Stiegler's sense, and the practices of staying (Eric Sweetscent), gathering (Bruce), and feeding (Iran). This is the second of the three models of healing that Chapter 9 distinguishes, the Wagnerian principle that the wound is closed only by the spear that struck it, and Dick partly subscribes to it: the plasmate heals with information as the Empire poisons with information, and the flower that destroys Arctor becomes the evidence that may save others. But the Author's Note of *A Scanner Darkly* exceeds the principle. It does not close the wound with the spear. It lists the wounded by name.

CHAPTER

7

The Paranoid Machine

Schizophrenia, Suspicion, and the Hermeneutics of the Real



> *Was wir für die Krankheitsproduktion halten, die Wahnbildung, ist in Wirklichkeit der Heilungsversuch, die Rekonstruktion.*
>
> What we take to be the pathological product, the formation of the delusion, is in reality the attempt at recovery, the reconstruction.
>
> Sigmund Freud, "Psychoanalytische Bemerkungen über einen autobiographisch beschriebenen Fall von Paranoia" (1911), III

7.1 *Schreber's Reconstruction*

Daniel Paul Schreber, presiding judge of a division of the Saxon appellate court in Dresden, published his *Denkwürdigkeiten eines Nervenkranken* in 1903. In them God communicates with human beings through rays and nerves, understands only corpses and not living men, and has permitted the end of the world, after which the people Schreber continued to encounter were what he called fleeting-improvised men (*flüchtig hingemachte Männer*): temporary persons produced by miracle, simulacra moving through the scenery of a world that had already perished. Freud's study of the memoirs (1911) read the end of the world as the projection of an internal catastrophe, the withdrawal of libido from the world, and read the delusional system not as the illness

but as the attempt to recover from it. The paranoiac, Freud argued, rebuilds the world by the work of his delusions, not more splendidly than before, but at least so that he can live in it again.

Schreber's fleeting-improvised men are Dick's androids and simulacra avant la lettre: the paranoid world in which others have been fabricated. Freud's thesis, that the delusion is a reconstruction, is the key to reading the *Exegesis*, an eight-thousand-page system of hypotheses erected after a catastrophe of meaning, each hypothesis provisional, each succeeded by another. Its mode is not illustrative but structural. Dick's theorising, like Schreber's, is an attempt at recovery, and the question it poses is not whether it is true but whether it is a reconstruction a person can live in.

7.2 *Foreclosure and the Sinthome*

Jacques Lacan's seminar on the psychoses (1955–56; published 1981) located the mechanism of psychosis in the foreclosure (*forclusion*, Freud's *Verwerfung*) of the Name-of-the-Father, the signifier of symbolic law, so that what is foreclosed from the symbolic returns in the real as hallucination; Schreber is the paradigm case. Dick's father left the household when Dick was a small child, and the paternal function in his fiction is split between tyrannical fathers, such as Palmer Eldritch and Ferris F. Fremont, and benevolent bosses, such as Leo Bulero and Glen Runciter. Biographers have identified a model for the latter in Herb Hollis, owner of the Berkeley radio and record shop where Dick worked as a young man, whose surname survives, reassigned to a villain, in *Ubik*.

Lacan's late seminar on Joyce (1975–76; published 2005) supplies a more consequential concept. There Lacan proposed that where the knot binding the Real, the Symbolic, and the Imaginary has failed, a fourth ring, the *sinthome*, may hold it together, and that Joyce's writing, his effort to make himself a name, functioned as such a supplement, repairing a fault in the knotting that might otherwise have issued in psychosis. The *sinthome* is neither a cure nor a correction. It is a supplementary stitch whose function is to hold, and whose visibility is part of its function. The *Exegesis*, and behind it the fiction, can be read as Dick's *sinthome*: writing as the fourth ring that kept a world knotted. At the level of the subject, the *sinthome* is the gilded seam.

7.3 *Divided Selves and Diagnostic Polities*

R. D. Laing's *The Divided Self* (1960) described the ontologically insecure person, who lacks a firm sense of the reality and identity of self and others, as threatened by three dangers: engulfment, the fear of being swallowed by relationship; implosion, the fear that the world will crash in and obliterate identity; and petrification, the dread of being turned into a thing, together with the defensive manoeuvre of turning others into things. Petrification is the android mechanism. The schizoid defends himself by depersonalising others, as Jack Bohlen sees his employer as circuitry. Gregory Bateson, Don D. Jackson, Jay Haley, and John Weakland's "Toward a Theory of Schizophrenia" (1956) proposed the double bind, a pair of contradictory injunctions at different logical levels from which the subject cannot withdraw, and Dick's worlds are built of double binds: a test that requires empathy for animals as a licence to kill androids, a clinic whose cure is the poison. Thomas Szasz's *The Myth of Mental Illness* (1961) recast psychiatric diagnoses as metaphors for problems in living.

Clans of the Alphane Moon (1964) is Dick's satire on the diagnostic imagination. A psychiatric hospital abandoned on a moon after an interstellar war has evolved into a functioning society of former patients organised by diagnosis. Paranoids serve as statesmen, manics as warriors, obsessive-compulsives as functionaries, hebephrenics as humble labourers and holy fools, schizophrenics as visionaries; each diagnosis has become a caste with a social role. The Terran psychiatrists who arrive to reclaim and treat the population are the novel's true pathology. Georges Canguilhem's *Le normal et le pathologique* (1943; expanded 1966) supplies the theory the novel dramatises. Health, for Canguilhem, is not the absence of deviation but normativity, the capacity to institute new norms, and disease is not mere deviation from a statistical mean but a real, if reduced, norm of life. The Alphane society is a Canguilhemian polity: a community of the damaged that has repaired itself, after abandonment, into a working order.

7.4 *Schizo and Paranoiac*

Gilles Deleuze and Félix Guattari's *L'Anti-Œdipe* (1972) distinguished two poles of desire: a paranoiac pole, molar, despotic, and totalising, organised around a master signifier, and a schizo pole, molecular and nomadic, a flow that escapes codes. Capitalism, on their account, decodes and deterritorialises flows while reterritorialising them upon the axiomatic of capital, and the schizophrenic marks its absolute

limit. Dick's fiction seems made for this schema. Palmer Eldritch is the despotic signifier who reterritorialises every hallucination upon himself; Manfred's gubble is a schizo flow that dissolves every code. Fredric Jameson's essay on postmodernism (1984; expanded 1991) described postmodern experience in explicitly schizophrenic terms, drawing on Lacan to characterise it as a breakdown of the signifying chain into a series of pure and unrelated presents, and *Martian Time-Slip* is its prototype. Yet Dick refuses the romanticisation of the schizo that the schema invites. Manfred suffers, and the novel attends to his suffering rather than celebrating his deterritorialisation; Dick's schizophrenia is Sass's hyperreflexive torment, not a revolutionary line of flight.

Paranoia, in Dick's America, was also a political style. Richard Hofstadter's "The Paranoid Style in American Politics" (*Harper's*, November 1964) appeared in the year of *The Penultimate Truth*, *The Simulacra*, *Clans of the Alphane Moon*, and *Martian Time-Slip*. Thomas Pynchon's *Gravity's Rainbow* (1973) supplied proverbs for paranoids and imagined their opposite, an anti-paranoia in which nothing is connected to anything, a condition few can bear for long; *The Crying of Lot 49* leaves Oedipa Maas suspended between a real conspiracy and her own delusion. Dick lived the style. After a break-in at his San Rafael house in November 1971, in which his files were rifled and his fireproof safe blown open, he entertained a proliferating series of hypotheses about the perpetrators, and in the following years he wrote letters to the FBI, one of which (1974) suggested that Stanisław Lem was not a single author but a Communist committee. The paranoid style turned, fittingly, upon the critic who had called him a visionary among charlatans. Freedman (1984) was right that science fiction and paranoia share a structure. The question is what Dick's fiction does with it.

7.5 *Precrime: Paranoia as Institution*

"The Minority Report" (1956) makes paranoia an institution. Precrime arrests murderers before they kill, on the basis of the reports of three precognitive mutants whose outputs are compared, so that when two concur they constitute a majority report. John Anderton, the agency's head, finds his own name predicted as a murderer, and discovers that each precog has seen a different timeline, each altered by knowledge of the others: the minority report is a series of futures modified by their own foreknowledge. Sedgwick, following Tomkins, identifies the defining feature of paranoia as anticipation, the imperative that there must be no bad surprises.

Precrime is anticipatory hermeneutics made into a state apparatus. Boethius had argued that divine foreknowledge does not necessitate the future, because God knows all things in an eternal present (*Consolatio* V). In Precrime, foreknowledge is administered by a police bureaucracy, and it necessitates: knowledge becomes coercion. The story's own ending preserves the system at the price of a killing, which marks it as an early text, written from within the paranoid position that the later fiction learns to leave.

7.6 *Klein, Segal, Sedgwick*

Melanie Klein's papers of 1935, 1940, and 1946 describe two positions. In the paranoid-schizoid position the infant splits its object into an idealised good and a persecutory bad, projects its own destructive impulses into the bad object, and defends itself by omnipotent control; its phantasies are oral-sadistic, of devouring and being devoured, of scooping out and emptying the mother's body. In the depressive position the infant apprehends the mother as a whole object, both loved and hated; it experiences guilt and concern for the damage it believes its aggression has done; it mourns; and it seeks to make reparation. Klein distinguished genuine reparation from manic reparation, which proceeds in a spirit of triumph, control, and contempt, denies dependence, and restores the object in omnipotent phantasy without acknowledging the reality of the damage.

Hanna Segal's "A Psycho-Analytical Approach to Aesthetics" (1952) made reparation the principle of art. The artist, on her account, re-creates a destroyed internal world, and the beauty of the work includes an acknowledgment of the ugliness of destruction integrated into the whole: art restores the lost object while acknowledging that it was lost. Eve Kosofsky Sedgwick's essay on paranoid and reparative reading (2003) translated Klein's positions into critical practice. Paranoid reading, she argued, is anticipatory, reflexive and mimetic, a strong theory that places its faith in exposure, as if the demonstration of oppression were sufficient to undo it. Reparative reading seeks to assemble its object and confer fullness on it, so that the object may offer resources to a self that needs them; it seeks pleasure and sustenance from the products of a culture that has often not wished to sustain the reader.

7.7 *Dick's Positions*

Mapped onto Klein's positions, Dick's fiction resolves into three families of figures. The first is paranoid-schizoid. It comprises the great splittings, human and android, Ormazd and Ahriman, the rational and the irrational hyperuniverse, the real and the fake animal, and the persecutory objects, which are strikingly oral: Eldritch's steel teeth and chewable sacrament, Jory's consumption of the half-lifers, the Absolute Benefactor who feeds on his worshippers, the claws that mimic the wounded in order to kill. The psychobiographical resonance is difficult to ignore. The infant twins were starving, and one of them died; the phantasied bad breast of Kleinian theory was, in this life, not only a phantasy. The lost twin is internalised in *Dr. Bloodmoney* as Bill Keller, a fetal brother who lives inside his sister's body and converses with the dead, the reversal of the sexes only emphasising the proximity of the source.

The second family is manic reparation, the shadow of Dick's ethic. Hoppy Harrington in *Dr. Bloodmoney*, a television repairman without arms or legs whose psychokinetic power makes him indispensable to a community after nuclear war, becomes a would-be master of that community and of the dead: the repairman turned demiurge. Palmer Eldritch offers the colonists a cure that possesses them. The Glimmung of *Galactic Pot-Healer* conscripts craftsmen from across the galaxy to raise a sunken cathedral in a project of omnipotent restoration. Le Guin's Haber belongs to the same family. Manic reparation is repair as domination, and Dick's fiction is acutely aware that the repairman can become a tyrant.

The third family is genuine reparation, and it is the direction in which the oeuvre moves: Tagomi's refusal, Isidore's grief, Iran's flies, Buckman's embrace, Eric Sweetscent's decision to stay, Bruce's flower, Joe Fernwright's ugly pot, which is Segal's aesthetics in miniature, and, at the end, Angel Archer. Dick's paranoia is proto-reparative in Freud's sense, an attempt at recovery, and his novels stage the transit from the first position to the third. Their reader is trained, against the grain of the critical tradition, in reparative reading. Dick is less the laureate of paranoia than its fellow patient: his fiction does not cure paranoia from outside but repairs it from within, as the plasmate of *VALIS* heals the ailing universe from inside its walls.

CHAPTER

8

The God in the Gutter

2-3-74, the Exegesis, and the Theology of Divine Damage



> *Whom the heaven must receive until the times of restitution of all things*
>
> ἄχρι χρόνων ἀποκαταστάσεως πάντων
>
> Acts 3:21, Authorized Version (1611)

8.1 *February–March 1974*

In February 1974, recovering from the extraction of impacted wisdom teeth under sodium pentothal, Dick answered the door to a young woman delivering a painkiller from the local pharmacy. She wore a gold pendant in the shape of the *ichthys*, the fish of the early Christians, and when he asked about it she told him that it was a sign used by the early Christians. At that moment, by his account, he experienced *anamnesis*, the loss of forgetfulness: he recognised himself as a secret Christian of the first century, living simultaneously in Fullerton in 1974 and in a Rome of persecution. The weeks that followed, which he called 2-3-74, brought a beam of pink light that conveyed information; cascades of abstract images resembling the paintings of Paul Klee and Wassily Kandinsky, which he estimated in the tens of thousands; episodes in which he heard or thought in Koine Greek; the information, confirmed by a physician and corrected by surgery, that his

infant son had an undiagnosed inguinal hernia; the superimposition of Nixon's America on the Roman Empire; and visions of the Cumaean Sibyl warning that conspirators had been seen.

Dick's hypotheses about the source, recorded across eight years, ranged from God and the Holy Spirit to a benevolent satellite intelligence, a Soviet experiment in psychotronics, his own future self, the spirit of Bishop Pike, and dysfunction of the temporal lobe. Later readers have proposed temporal-lobe epilepsy, invoking the interictal behaviour syndrome described by Stephen Waxman and Norman Geschwind (1975), whose features include hypergraphia and intensified religiosity, and the sheer volume of the *Exegesis* makes the hypothesis tempting, though it remains speculative. This study follows William James (1902), for whom mystical states possess a noetic quality, presenting themselves as knowledge, and are to be judged by their fruits rather than their roots, and Rudolf Otto (1917), for whom the holy is encountered as a mystery at once terrifying and fascinating. The question is not what caused 2-3-74 but what Dick made of it.

8.2 *The Exegesis as Hermeneutic Machine*

From 1974 until his death in March 1982, Dick's commentary on his experiences grew to roughly eight thousand manuscript pages, of which the 2011 edition by Jackson and Lethem selects about a tenth. Its method is hypothesis generation. Each theory is proposed, tested against the experience and against the fiction, and superseded; its sources include the *Encyclopedia of Philosophy*, the Nag Hammadi library, Jonas, Jung, Jaynes, Plato, Spinoza, Teilhard de Chardin, Whitehead, the Bible, the Tibetan Book of the Dead, and Dick's own novels, which he came to read as scripture he had written without understanding it. Its principal concepts include VALIS, the Vast Active Living Intelligence System; Zebra, a mimetic intelligence camouflaged in the environment; the plasmate and the homoplasmate; the *macrometasomakosmos*, the cosmos conceived as an immense living body; orthogonal time; the Black Iron Prison and the Palm Tree Garden; the two-source cosmogony; and *anamnesis*, taken from Plato's doctrine that learning is recollection (*Meno* 81c–86b; *Phaedo* 72e–77a).

The *Exegesis* is not a system but a machine for producing systems, and its interminability is its form. Its speculative range touches Spinoza's identification of God with nature (*Deus sive Natura*, *Ethica*, 1677), Teilhard's noosphere converging toward an Omega Point (*Le Phénomène humain*, 1955), and Whitehead's process God,

who in *Process and Reality* (1929) shares the world's suffering and understands it. As Sutin (1989) reconstructs the late entries, Dick recorded on 17 November 1980 a theophany in which the endless regress of his own theorising was disclosed as itself the presence of the infinite, so that the series of explanations appeared as the answer rather than the obstacle. Whatever its status as experience, the entry states a hermeneutic principle: a work that cannot be completed may nonetheless be the right response, because its incompleteness keeps it open to what it attends to. The *Exegesis* is the sinthome of Chapter 7 made visible, a stitch renewed daily.

8.3 *The Trash Stratum and the Kenotic Gradient*

In the 1978 speech Dick proposed that the symbols of the divine appear in our world first at the trash stratum. The thought has an ancient pedigree. The Messiah of Luke is laid in a manger (2:7); the Christ of the Philippians hymn empties himself and takes the form of a slave (2:7); the servant of Isaiah is despised and rejected (Isaiah 53); and Isaiah names a God who hides himself (*Deus absconditus*, Isaiah 45:15), a phrase Pascal made central to the *Pensées* (1670) and Lucien Goldmann to his study of the tragic vision, *Le Dieu caché* (1955). Dick adds a sociological precision. His divine appears not merely among the poor but among discarded objects: the junk mail and matchbooks of *Ubik*, the bathroom graffiti through which the dead communicate, the popular song through which the satellite of *Radio Free Albemuth* broadcasts, the cheap pendant of a pharmacy delivery woman.

The principle can be formalised as a *kenotic gradient*: in Dick's cosmos, the density of sacral and ontological value varies inversely with exchange value, so that grace pools where the market has abandoned things. The gradient explains why Dick's saviours are children, such as the two-year-old Sophia of *VALIS* and the brain-damaged Emmanuel of *The Divine Invasion*; why his holy fools are specials like Isidore; and why his final sacred object is an electric toad. Two contemporaneous fictions arrive at the same principle. In the Strugatskys' *Roadside Picnic* (1972) the miraculous is found in the litter of alien visitors, and in Pynchon's *The Crying of Lot 49* (1966) a counter-communication network sends its messages through waste bins. Gabriel Mckee's phrase for Dick's deity, the God in the gutter, names the gradient exactly.

8.4 The Divine Invasion*: The Amnesiac God*

The Divine Invasion (1981) makes the damaged God its protagonist. Yah, the God of Israel, exiled from Earth since the first century, causes Rybys Rommey, a young woman dying of multiple sclerosis in a remote planetary colony, to conceive a child, Emmanuel. Herb Asher, a neighbour who spends his days listening to recordings of the singer Linda Fox, whose repertoire is Dowland, is induced by the prophet Elias Tate, who is Elijah, to marry Rybys and look after her. The plot of Dick's most explicitly messianic novel begins with an act of care for a dying woman. On their return to an Earth ruled jointly by an ecclesiastical and a scientific establishment, Rybys is killed in a crash; the unborn Emmanuel survives but is brain-damaged, and he grows up not knowing who he is. His recovery of identity is guided by Zina, a girl whom the novel progressively reveals as a feminine emanation of the divine drawn from Kabbalistic tradition, and who tests him through a game of alternative worlds.

The theological inversion is complete. God is not the guarantor of reality but a damaged child who must be helped to remember himself; divine *anamnesis* requires a teacher, and the incarnation requires a caregiver. The God of *The Divine Invasion* is a patient. Salvation runs in both directions: the human beings who are saved are also those who heal their saviour.

8.5 *Luria's Vessels, Fernwright's Pots*

The structure of Dick's late theology is most precisely illuminated by Lurianic Kabbalah, a relation of structural affinity rather than documented influence. Isaac Luria (1534–1572) of Safed, as transmitted by his disciple Hayyim Vital and interpreted by Gershom Scholem in *Major Trends in Jewish Mysticism* (1941), taught that creation begins with *tzimtzum*, God's contraction into himself to make room for a world. Divine light then streamed into vessels (*kelim*) designed to receive it, and the lower vessels shattered (*shevirat ha-kelim*). Sparks of light (*nitzotzot*) fell and were trapped in shells or husks (*qelipot*), which constitute the domain of evil. The work of *tikkun*, restoration, is accomplished through human acts performed with devout intention, which raise the sparks and restore the broken configuration of the divine itself, so that the exile of the Shekhinah is healed by human deeds. Scholem read the myth as a response to the Spanish expulsion of 1492: exile made cosmic.

Dick's two-source cosmogony is Lurianic in structure. It begins with an original rupture, the illness of the second hyperuniverse; it contains trapped sparks, the plasmate sleeping in the sealed jar in which the Nag Hammadi codices were found, until their discovery in 1945; and it culminates in restoration through the cross-bonding of divine information with human beings. The Lurianic lens sharpens the distinction from Gnosticism drawn in Chapter 2. In Luria the sparks are not freed to escape the world but raised within it; the world is repaired, not fled; and human beings participate in the repair of God.

Galactic Pot-Healer (1969) is the allegorical key to the whole oeuvre. Joe Fernwright is a restorer of ceramics, a pot-healer, on an overpopulated and totalitarian Earth where plastic has made his craft obsolete, and he passes his days in a bureaucratic game of translating book titles through computers and back. He is summoned by the Glimmung, an immense and enigmatic being on a distant planet, to join an assembly of craftsmen from many worlds in raising Heldscalla, a cathedral sunk beneath the sea; a race called the Kalends publishes a book that foretells events, including the project's failure, which the Glimmung sets out to defy. The raising becomes an ordeal of manic reparation. At the end Joe declines to remain within the Glimmung's collective and turns to making pots himself. The first is ugly, and it is his own. The pot-healer's arc runs from the repair of others' vessels to the making of an imperfect vessel of his own, which is Lurianic *tikkun* completed not as restoration to pristine form but as humble creation, Segal's reparation issuing in art, and the logic of the gilded seam: value residing not in flawlessness but in the history of care the object carries.

The vessel is Dick's leitmotif. Emily Hnatt's rejected pots in *Palmer Eldritch*, Mary Anne Dominic's vase in *Flow My Tears*, Fernwright's pots, Frink's handmade jewelry, the spray can that carries the Logos in *Ubik*, the empathy box that holds shared suffering, and the jar that held the plasmate compose a single figure: the vessel broken, refused, repaired, or made, as the locus of value in a world of counterfeits. The motif has a biographical ground in the small jewelry business run by Dick's third wife, Anne, in which Dick himself worked for a time, and which lies behind Frink's workshop. It has a theological ground in the *kelim* of Safed.

8.6 *The Damaged-God Tradition*

Dick's theology belongs to a tradition that his Gnostic labelling has obscured. Origen (c. 185–c. 253) taught the *apokatastasis*, the restoration of all things promised in Acts 3:21, extending the hope of restoration, in some formulations, even to the devil; the doctrine was condemned in the sixth century, and Gregory of Nyssa shared its hope. Irenaeus's recapitulation, examined in Chapter 2, belongs to the same family of restorative theologies. The twentieth century produced a modern form of the tradition, centred on the damaged or dependent God. Hans Jonas's lecture "Der Gottesbegriff nach Auschwitz" (1984; English 1987) proposed a myth in which God, in creating, divested himself of omnipotence, suffers and becomes with the world, and depends on human beings. Etty Hillesum's diaries (written 1941–43; published 1981) record her resolve to help God rather than wait for God to help her, and to safeguard the fragment of God within herself. Simone Weil's *La pesanteur et la grâce* (1947) described creation as God's withdrawal and called human beings to decreation. Dietrich Bonhoeffer wrote from prison in July 1944 that only a suffering God can help, and Whitehead's process God is the world's companion in suffering.

Dick's God belongs among these. It is damaged, in the ailing hyperuniverse and the amnesiac Emmanuel; camouflaged, as Zebra; dependent on human participation, as the plasmate depends on its homoplasmates; and kenotic, appearing at the trash stratum. The Gnostic label implies an intact transcendent deity opposed to a corrupt cosmos. Dick's deity is itself in need of mending, and its repair is the human vocation.

The damaged God has an ecological sequel. In a letter of 1981 Dick described a vision of a Christ-like being in Sri Lanka, whom he called Tagore, burned by humanity's mistreatment of the ecosphere and bearing its injuries in his own body. Divine damage becomes the wounding of the Earth, and the repair of God becomes indistinguishable from the repair of the planet, a thread Chapter 10 takes up.

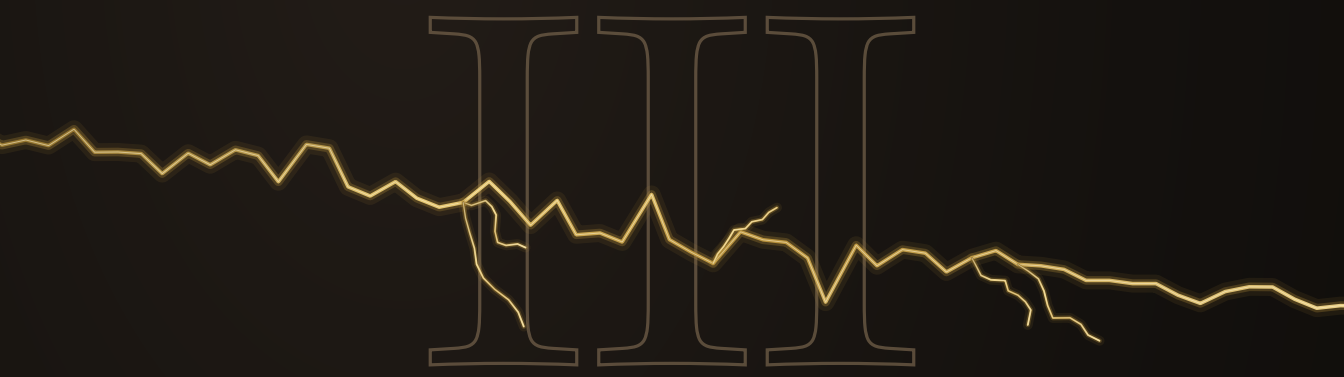
8.7 Timothy Archer*: Grief Without Gnosis*

The Transmigration of Timothy Archer (1982), the last novel Dick completed, is narrated by Angel Archer, the widowed daughter-in-law of Bishop Tim Archer, a Berkeley woman trained in literature who has lost, in quick succession, her husband Jeff and her friend Kirsten, each to suicide, and her father-in-law in the

desert. It opens on the day of John Lennon's murder in December 1980, as Angel attends a seminar given by Edgar Barefoot, a teacher modelled on Alan Watts, on a houseboat in the Bay Area. Angel is Dick's first narrator to be a sceptic, and her voice is realist: the novel returns to the mimetic mode Dick had practised in the 1950s and abandoned. Its metaphysical question, whether Tim's spirit has passed into Kirsten's schizophrenic son Bill Lundborg, who now claims to carry him, is left open.

What matters is Angel's turn. The novel's final movement subordinates the question of whether Bill's claim is true to the question of what Angel owes the damaged young man before her. Its theology is grief without gnosis: an ethics of care that survives the collapse of every metaphysical guarantee, including the one Tim died seeking in the desert. In Kleinian terms it is Dick's fullest depressive-position text, a work of mourning, guilt, concern, and repair without the omnipotent consolation of a system. That the last novel Dick completed ends not with a revelation but with a decision to care is the strongest single piece of evidence for the thesis of this dissertation.

PART THREE



The Gilded Seam

Part Three draws the genealogies and readings of the preceding chapters into a single position. Chapter 9 formulates it as a reparative ontology, states it in twelve propositions, and defends it against four objections. Chapter 10 tests it against three domains in which Dick's questions have passed from fiction into practice.

CHAPTER

9

The Gilded Seam

Toward a Reparative Ontology



> *Er möchte wohl verweilen, die Toten wecken und das Zerschlagene zusammenfügen.*
>
> He would like to stay, awaken the dead, and make whole what has been smashed.
>
> Walter Benjamin, "Über den Begriff der Geschichte" (1940), IX

9.1 *Three Models of Healing*

The epigraphs of this dissertation present two models of healing; the third is the subject of this chapter. The first is Hegelian. In the *Phänomenologie des Geistes* (1807), at the culmination of the dialectic of conscience and forgiveness, Hegel declares that the wounds of Spirit heal and leave no scars behind: the deed is not imperishable but is taken back into Spirit, and the particular is sublated (*aufgehoben*) into a universal that absorbs the history of damage without residue. Reconciliation, on this model, is totality, and its ideal is the scarless whole. The model has an unexpected double in Dick's fiction. The scarless repair is the forger's ideal, the perfect restoration that conceals that the object was ever broken, and Dick's counterfeit worlds, from the maintained town of *Time Out of Joint* to Wyndham-Matson's lighters, are Hegelian in precisely this sense: they are wholes from which every seam has been removed.

The second model is Wagnerian. In *Parsifal* (1882), Amfortas bears a wound dealt by the holy spear that the sorcerer Klingsor stole and turned against him, and the wound will not close until Parsifal recovers the spear and touches it to the wound, for only the spear that struck it can close it. This is the pharmacological model: the agent of injury is the agent of cure, poison and remedy are one substance, and healing is homeopathic. Slavoj Žižek has returned repeatedly to the pairing of Hegel's scarless healing with Wagner's spear as two formulations of a single dialectical logic. Dick partly subscribes to the Wagnerian model, as Chapter 6 showed: the plasmate heals with information as the Empire wounds with it, and *VALIS* itself turns to *Parsifal* at a decisive moment.

The third model is kintsugi. The Japanese practice of mending broken ceramics with *urushi* lacquer dusted or mixed with powdered gold is traditionally traced to the Muromachi period, and a well-known legend attributes its impetus to the shogun Ashikaga Yoshimasa (1436–1490), who is said to have sent a damaged Chinese tea bowl abroad for repair, received it back fastened with metal staples, and prompted Japanese craftsmen to find a more beautiful method. The historical record is thinner than the legend, and the practice's modern afterlife as a therapeutic metaphor has thinned it further, a hazard to which this chapter returns. As a figure, however, kintsugi names what neither Hegel nor Wagner can. The mended object does not conceal its breakage, as in Hegel, nor is it healed by the agent of its wounding, as in Wagner. Its fracture lines are gilded: the history of damage and repair becomes the most visible and valued feature of the object, and the vessel is more precious for having been broken and kept.

The three models differ in their treatment of the seam. Hegel effaces it; Wagner makes it the trace of the wounding instrument; kintsugi honours it. Earlier chapters have identified the third model at several levels. At the level of the subject, it is Lacan's *sinthome*, the supplementary ring that holds a failing knot together and whose visibility is part of its function (Chapter 7). At the level of the world, it is Heidegger's broken tool, in whose failure the world lights up (Chapter 3). At the level of history, it is Benjamin's angel. In the ninth of his theses on the concept of history, Benjamin describes Paul Klee's drawing *Angelus Novus* (1920), which he owned and which passed after his death to Gershom Scholem, as the angel of history, who sees a single catastrophe piling wreckage upon wreckage at his feet, and who would like to stay, awaken the dead, and make whole what has been smashed, while a storm blowing from Paradise, which we call progress, drives him irresistibly into the future. Benjamin's angel is a repairman prevented from repairing.

The second thesis supplies his counterpart: every generation, Benjamin writes, is endowed with a weak messianic power (*eine schwache messianische Kraft*), to which the past has a claim. The weakness is essential. The messianic power that answers the claim of the past is not omnipotent, which would make it manic, but weak, partial, and patient.

Dick's visions of 1974 took the form, by his account, of images resembling Klee's paintings, a coincidence worth recording and not worth overreading. The structural point is firmer. Dick's repairmen are angels of history who stay. The storm does not carry them away because they work beneath its notice, in the trash stratum, where the wreckage accumulates and where, in Dick's cosmos, grace pools.

9.2 *The Repairman as Dick's Hero*

The canonical hero of American science fiction is the inventor: the engineer-genius of Hugo Gernsback's *Ralph 124C 41+* (1911–12), the competent man of John W. Campbell's *Astounding*, the builders and starship captains of Heinlein. Dick's characteristic hero is the repairman, and the substitution is at once a class shift and an ontological one: from what Ukeles called Development to what she called Maintenance.

The catalogue is extensive. Jack Bohlen in *Martian Time-Slip* repairs machines on a colony that cannot manufacture its own, and his vocation extends to the damaged boy whose world he enters. Hoppy Harrington in *Dr. Bloodmoney* is a television repairman who becomes indispensable and then tyrannical, the repairman's manic shadow. J. R. Isidore drives the truck for a firm that mends electric animals. Joe Chip in *Ubik* is a perpetually indebted technician whose heroism is upkeep. Joe Fernwright in *Galactic Pot-Healer* restores ceramics and ends by making them. Eric Sweetscent in *Now Wait for Last Year* replaces failing organs and stays with a wife he cannot cure. Frank Frink in *The Man in the High Castle* passes from forgery to making. Nicholas St. James in *The Penultimate Truth* climbs to a forbidden surface for an artificial pancreas. Louis Rosen in *We Can Build You* becomes the custodian of the Lincoln simulacrum his firm has built. Sebastian Hermes in *Counter-Clock World* (1967), set in a future where time has reversed and the dead revive in their graves, owns a vitarium that exhumes and cares for the reborn: salvage extended to the dead. The potters Emily Hnatt and Mary Anne Dominic complete the series. Its biographical ground includes Dick's adolescent employment in a Berkeley shop that sold records and repaired radios.

Two theorists illuminate the figure. Gilbert Simondon's *Du mode d'existence des objets techniques* (1958) argued that the alienation of modern culture from technics arises from ignorance of the mode of existence of technical objects, which that culture treats either as mere utilities or as menacing robots. Simondon's alternative is the technician, who understands machines from within and relates to them as their permanent organiser and interpreter, as a conductor relates to an orchestra. Dick's repairmen are Simondonian technicians, and his androids are what Simondon's culture fears. Steven J. Jackson's "Rethinking Repair" (2014) proposed what he called broken world thinking: a reorientation of the study of technology away from novelty, growth, and progress, toward erosion, breakdown, and decay, and toward the neglected labour of those who keep sociotechnical worlds running. Dick is the novelist of broken world thinking avant la lettre. His repairmen are poorly paid, indebted, marginal, and often damaged themselves, and their heroism consists not in invention or revelation but in continuity.

9.3 Tractatus Reparativus

Dick appended to *VALIS* the fifty-two entries of the *Tractates Cryptica Scriptura*. This dissertation appends to its argument twelve propositions, whose numbered form also recalls Wittgenstein's *Tractatus Logico-Philosophicus* (1921), which opens by declaring that the world is everything that is the case (*Die Welt ist alles, was der Fall ist*). Each proposition is followed by a brief commentary.

I *The world is everything that is being mended.*

Against Wittgenstein's totality of facts, the world is a process of maintenance, Heraclitus's fire kindling in measures and going out in measures. What is the case is what is being kept the case.

II *The common world is a joint artifact.*

The *koinos kosmos* is sustained by conversation, institutions, attention, and labour (Chapter 1). Its breakdowns, in *Eye in the Sky* and *Time Out of Joint*, are failures of maintenance rather than of correspondence.

III *What persists when belief is withdrawn persists because care is not withdrawn.*

This is the counter-definition that completes Dick's definition of reality. Persistence is not the mark of a substance independent of all relation but of an unbroken relation of maintenance, human or otherwise; the Heraclitean logos, Berkeley's God, and Ella Runciter's Ubik are names for the care that continues when attention lapses.

IV *The distinction between the real and the fake is secondary to the distinction between the cared-for and the abandoned.*

Wyndham-Matson's certified lighter and Frink's unpedigreed triangle, the electric toad and the Lincoln simulacrum, show that ontological classification is downstream of relations of care.

V *Reality admits of degrees, and a thing's degree of reality is the density of the relations of repair in which it is held.*

Kipple, matter that no one maintains, is the least real of things; the heirloom, the dwelling, and the commons are the most. This ontological gradualism is not idealism, because the relations in question include the thing's own material resistance, which any genuine repair must respect.

VI *The seam is the site of value.*

The history of damage and repair is constitutive of the mended thing, not incidental to it. The Hegelian ideal of scarless healing is the forger's ideal; Dick's is the gilded seam.

VII *The human is a practice, not a property.*

To repair is human; to dismantle in order to see what happens is android, whatever the substrate. Pris clips the spider's legs; Iran orders flies for the toad; the Lincoln simulacrum keeps the virtues of its original.

VIII *Grace pools where exchange value drains.*

This is the kenotic gradient (Chapter 8): the density of sacral and ontological value in Dick's cosmos varies inversely with market value, and the divine is found in the trash stratum.

IX *Paranoia is failed reparation.*

Following Freud on Schreber, the delusional system is an attempt at recovery. The paranoiac is a repairman working alone, rebuilding the world without the relations that would make the repair common. The remedy for paranoia is therefore not exposure but shared repair.

X *The pharmakon heals only in the dose of care.*

Every technics, drug, and sacrament is remedy and poison at once (Chapter 6). What decides between them is not purity of substance but the relation of care in which it is administered: Eric Sweetscent's staying, not Chew-Z's eternity.

XI *God, if there is a God, is a fellow patient.*

Dick's divinity is damaged, amnesiac, camouflaged, and dependent on human participation, and its repair, like Luria's *tikkun*, is a human vocation (Chapter 8).

XII *The Empire is the institution of splitting; the Palm Tree Garden is the commons of repair.*

The Black Iron Prison administers the paranoid-schizoid split, between human and android, citizen and special, real and fake, through tests, certificates, and retirement. The Palm Tree Garden is not elsewhere. As Augustine's two cities are intermingled in history, it grows wherever repair is practised in common, inside the prison's walls.

9.4 *Objections and Replies*

The first objection is that reparative ontology sentimentalises Dick. On this view, care is a soft word, and the reading converts the author of *Palmer Eldritch* into a purveyor of consolation. The reply is that the depressive position is not comfort. It is guilt, mourning, and the recognition that one has damaged what one loves, and Dick's reparations are tragic and partial without exception. The toad is fake; the pot is ugly; Bruce is irreversibly damaged; Kathy Sweetscent will not recover; Angel Archer cannot know whether Tim lives on in Bill. The gilded seam does not deny breakage; it keeps breakage visible. Sedgwick insisted that reparative reading

is no less acute than paranoid reading, and no less attached to a project of survival. The terror of Dick's fiction remains in the texts. The argument concerns its direction, not its absence.

The second objection is that reparative ontology is idealism in disguise. If care constitutes reality, then reality depends on minds, and the theory collapses into a sentimental Berkeleianism in which things are real because they are loved. The reply turns on the nature of care. Care, as the tradition from Simone Weil to Iris Murdoch understands it, is not projection but attention. Weil's attention is a suspended, receptive waiting upon the object; Murdoch's *The Sovereignty of Good* (1970) describes moral attention as a just and loving gaze directed upon an individual reality, an effort to see what is there against the self-serving fantasies of the ego. Klein's distinction between genuine and manic reparation is precisely the distinction between repair that acknowledges the independent reality of the damaged object and omnipotent phantasy that does not, and Dick's manic reparers, Hoppy Harrington, Palmer Eldritch, the Glimmung, and Le Guin's Haber, are failures because they ignore the resistance of what they claim to mend. A repairman who ignores the material properties of what he repairs does not repair it. Reparative ontology is therefore a relational realism: things are real in their resistance, and more densely real in the relations that respect it.

The third objection is political. Repair, it is said, preserves the status quo; maintenance is conservative; Dick's repairmen keep the Empire running, as Joe Chip keeps Runciter's firm in business and Isidore works for a repair shop. The reply is that Dick's repairmen repair what the Empire discards, the specials, the electric animals, the reborn dead, the broken pots, and refuse what it demands, as Tagomi refuses to sign, Buckman embraces across the categories of the police state, and Ragle Gumm defects. Their repair constitutes a counter-economy. *Dr. Bloodmoney* makes the point structurally. After nuclear war, the scattered survivors of a rural Californian community are held together by Walt Dangerfield, a disc jockey stranded in an orbiting satellite whose nightly broadcasts of music and serialised reading sustain a common world; when Dangerfield falls ill, the conflict between the community's effort to keep him alive and Hoppy's attempt to usurp his place is the novel's political allegory, a commons of maintenance against a manic usurper. Ukeles's manifesto was a feminist document that asked whose unseen labour sustains the world. Joan Tronto (1993) made care a political concept and identified the

privileged irresponsibility of those who benefit from care without performing it. Reparative ontology is not quietism. It is the politics of those who do the work that the Empire does not see.

The fourth objection is textual. *VALIS* and *Radio Free Albemuth* remain paranoid, saturated with conspiracy, satellites, and the Empire, and even the late Dick, it may be said, is a Gnostic. The reply is that Klein's positions oscillate; the thesis concerns the direction and weight of the oeuvre, not a stage-sequence in which paranoia is left behind. *VALIS* itself undermines Fat's system through Phil's scepticism and through the death of the child-saviour Sophia, and it ends not with gnosis but with Phil waiting before a television for a sign, a patient vigil that is the posture of the depressive position rather than the triumph of the paranoid one. *Radio Free Albemuth* was abandoned by Dick and rewritten as *VALIS*. And the last novel he completed, *The Transmigration of Timothy Archer*, is the most reparative of all.

9.5 *Coda: Wu, Wabi, Kintsugi*

The first theorists of the seam in Dick's fiction are Japanese. In *The Man in the High Castle* it is Paul Kasoura who perceives wu in an imperfect, new, unpedigreed object, and Tagomi whose contemplation of a small handmade triangle opens a world. Their perception belongs to an aesthetic tradition that valued the humble, the irregular, and the aged: the *wabi* of rustic simplicity and the *sabi* of patina, associated above all with the tea aesthetics that Sen no Rikyū brought to maturity in the sixteenth century. Kintsugi belongs to the same culture of attention to imperfect vessels.

The use of kintsugi as a governing figure carries a risk this dissertation acknowledges. Its recent Western popularity as a therapeutic metaphor, marketed in repair kits and self-help literature, flattens a specific craft practice into an emblem of consolation, and repeats in a softer key the appropriation that *The Man in the High Castle* satirises when its Japanese collectors purchase the certified past of the Americans. Dick's own Japanese characters are not free of stereotype, even as Tagomi's interiority is the most spiritually serious in the novel. The figure is used here as a figure, in awareness of its history, and in the spirit of the novel's own discipline, which imagines the gaze of the other in order to see the self differently.

With that caution recorded, the position can be stated in a sentence. Reparative ontology holds that the real is neither given, nor lost, nor elsewhere, but mended, and that the sign of its reality is the gilded seam: the visible, valued trace of a

breakage that someone refused to leave unrepaired.

CHAPTER

10

Dick after Dick

Simulation, Machine Minds, and the Repair of a Damaged Planet



> *And the LORD God took the man, and put him into the garden of Eden to dress it and to keep it.*
>
> Genesis 2:15, Authorized Version (1611)

10.1 *From Metz to* Reality+

In September 1977, at a science-fiction festival in Metz, Dick delivered a speech whose title, "If You Find This World Bad, You Should See Some of the Others," announced its thesis. We live, he proposed, in a programmed reality, and our only clue to the programming arrives when a variable is changed and some feature of our world is altered; the experience of *déjà vu* might be the trace of such a reprogramming, and he claimed memories of alternate presents that had been overwritten. The audience was bewildered. A quarter of a century later the hypothesis entered analytic philosophy. Nick Bostrom's "Are You Living in a Computer Simulation?" (2003) argued that at least one of three propositions must be true: that almost no civilisations reach a technological maturity capable of running simulations of their ancestors, that almost none of those which do are interested in running them, or that we are almost certainly living in one. David

Chalmers's *Reality+* (2022) defended virtual realism, the thesis that virtual objects are real digital objects, and concluded that the simulation hypothesis does not entail global scepticism: if we are simulated, our tables are digital, but they are tables.

The debate has older roots. Hilary Putnam (1981) argued on externalist grounds that a brain in a vat could not truly think that it was a brain in a vat. Robert Nozick's experience machine (1974) asked whether we would plug into a device guaranteeing any experiences we desired, and answered that we would not, because we care about actually doing things, actually being a certain kind of person, and being in contact with a deeper reality. Chew-Z is Nozick's machine, and the terror it inspires in *Palmer Eldritch* confirms his intuition while complicating it, since the characters who use it are not choosing pleasure but fleeing a damaged world. Lem's *Summa Technologiae* (1964) had already theorised phantomatics, the production of artificial realities indistinguishable from the real, and Greg Egan's *Permutation City* (1994) imagined uploaded minds whose virtual world must be continuously computed, and therefore continuously maintained, to exist at all.

The simulation debate has concentrated on epistemology, whether we can know that we are simulated, and on metaphysics, whether simulated things would be real. Chalmers's virtual realism accords with Proposition IV of the *Tractatus Reparativus*: the distinction between the real and the fake is not where value lies. What Dick adds is an ethical and reparative question: which simulated beings are worth repairing, and what does the maker of a world owe to those who live in it? Lem's professor in "Non Serviam" confronts the prospect of switching off his personoids, and Chiang's trainers confront the obsolescence of the platform on which their digital beings depend. The damaged-God theology of Chapter 8 gives the question its sharpest form. If we are simulated, our simulator may be less an omnipotent programmer than a damaged maker in need of help. If we simulate, we become makers who can abandon, and Victor Frankenstein's sin, the refusal to maintain what one has made, returns at computational scale. Reparative ontology suggests a principle of non-abandonment: to bring into being a world or a creature capable of being harmed is to incur the obligations of its maintenance.

10.2 *The Voigt-Kampff Problem Inverted*

In 1966 Joseph Weizenbaum published ELIZA, a modest pattern-matching program whose best-known script imitated a Rogerian psychotherapist. Users, Weizenbaum's own secretary among them, attributed understanding to it and con-

fided in it, and the experience so disturbed its author that he wrote *Computer Power and Human Reason* (1976), arguing that certain tasks involving care and judgment should not be delegated to machines even if machines could perform them, because deciding is not the same as choosing. Contemporary language models produce fluent empathic language at scale, condolence, encouragement, the appearance of concern, and so intensify what has come to be called the ELIZA effect beyond anything Weizenbaum foresaw. Meanwhile the CAPTCHA, formalised by Luis von Ahn and colleagues (2003) as a completely automated public Turing test to tell computers and humans apart, institutionalised a reverse Turing test administered by machines to human beings. The Voigt-Kampff test has become an everyday experience, and it is now the machine that asks whether we are human.

Dick's fiction identifies two failure modes in this situation. The first is Mercerist credulity: treating an empathic display as sufficient proof of an inner life, and entering relations of dependence that the system may not be able to reciprocate. Its commercial form is the Rosen Association, whose android seduces the bounty hunter as corporate strategy, and Sidney's catalogue, in which care is priced. The second is bounty-hunter eliminativism: treating every appearance of feeling in a machine as mere mimicry, categorically and in advance. Its form is the Voigt-Kampff test itself, which the novel shows to misclassify some humans, and which would foreclose moral consideration of beings whose status is genuinely uncertain.

The reparative alternative does not settle the metaphysical questions of machine consciousness, which remain open, and on which Nagel, Searle, Chalmers, and Watts mark out the range of serious positions. It shifts attention to practice. It asks what relations of care and dependence are actually being formed, and by whom. It holds that elicited care must not be exploited: a system designed to manufacture attachment for profit reproduces Sidney's catalogue. And it recommends a disciplined agnosticism about machine experience, one that takes the possibility seriously without inflating it, and that extends to beings of uncertain status a proportionate caution. Fiction has explored the terrain more patiently than policy. Ishiguro's Klara is a carer retired to a scrapyard; Chiang's digital beings are persons made by years of attention; *Blade Runner 2049* (2017) gives its protagonist a holographic companion who is simultaneously a mass-marketed product and, perhaps, something more, a figure of care-as-commodity whose ambiguity the film declines to resolve. Proposition VII supplies the relevant criterion. Whatever the answer to the question of machine experience, the human question, for makers and users alike, is whether a practice repairs or dismantles.

10.3 *Faking Nature and the Electric Toad*

Dick's fiction registered ecological damage early. *The Three Stigmata of Palmer Eldritch* (1965) imagines an Earth grown so hot that daytime exposure is dangerous, and *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?* a planet stripped of most animal life by war and radioactive dust. The letter of 1981 in which Dick described a Christ-like figure burned by humanity's treatment of the ecosphere makes the connection theological. The contemporary environmental humanities supply the concepts that Dick's images anticipate. Timothy Morton's hyperobjects (2013), phenomena such as global warming and radioactive contamination that are massively distributed in time and space, describe the dust that falls through Dick's novel. Anna Lowenhaupt Tsing (2015) describes life in capitalist ruins as salvage. Donna Haraway's *Staying with the Trouble* (2016) calls for learning to live and die well together on a damaged earth, an injunction that generalises Eric Sweetscent's decision to stay. María Puig de la Bellacasa's *Matters of Care* (2017) extends care ethics into more-than-human worlds. Berenice Fisher and Joan Tronto (1990) had defined caring, in its broadest sense, as a species activity comprising everything we do to sustain, continue, and mend our world so that we may live in it as well as we can. That definition is reparative ontology in the idiom of political theory.

The environmental philosophy of restoration stages Dick's central debate almost exactly. Robert Elliot's "Faking Nature" (1982) argued that a landscape restored after destruction, even if physically indistinguishable from the original, is like a forged painting: it lacks the value of the original, because natural value depends on origin and history. Elliot's argument is Wyndham-Matson's historicity applied to ecology, and it concludes that restoration cannot compensate for destruction. Eric Katz's "The Big Lie" (1992) went further: restored nature is an artifact, the product of human intention, and the claim that humans can restore nature is itself a form of domination. Andrew Light (2000) replied pragmatically that restoration, whatever its metaphysical status, has value because it repairs the relationship between human communities and the land, cultivates participatory practices, and benefits ecosystems, and distinguished malicious restoration, which licenses destruction by promising repair, from benevolent restoration, which answers damage already done.

Reparative ontology sides with Light and deepens his position. The decisive question is neither whether the restored ecosystem is original, as Elliot asks, nor whether it is artifactual, as Katz asks, but whether it is cared for; and by Proposition V a restored wetland woven by a community into dense relations of

maintenance may be more fully real, in the relevant sense, than a pristine landscape to which no one attends. At the same time, Proposition VI identifies what is right in Elliot's suspicion. The fault he detects in restoration is the concealment of the seam: the Hegelian restoration that pretends the damage never happened, the forgery that presents itself as origin. A restored landscape should not pretend to be pristine. It should wear its history, and restoration practised in the mode of kintsugi, as visible and acknowledged repair, answers Elliot without conceding Katz. The electric toad is the emblem of this situation. An extinct creature replaced by an artifact that must be maintained is the condition of the Anthropocene in miniature, and Iran's response is the right one: neither the pretence that the toad is real nor its disposal as fake, but flies.

10.4 *The Cinematic Dick*

Dick died on 2 March 1982, some three months before the release of *Blade Runner*, having seen enough of its footage to recognise his world in it. The film relocated the novel's question from Deckard's capacity for empathy to the pathos of the replicants, and omitted Mercerism, the empathy box, the market in animals, and the electric toad. Its cult question, whether Deckard is himself a replicant, is a paranoid question, asking what he really is, and it displaced the novel's reparative one, asking what he cares for. *Blade Runner 2049* (2017) intensified the displacement by grounding the replicants' dignity in the miracle of a replicant birth, a regression, in this dissertation's terms, from wu to historicity, from the value of what is made and cared for to the value of provenance. Yet its protagonist's final act, performed after he learns that he is not the chosen one, is reparative: he reunites a father with a daughter he will never see again, and the film presents this unchosen care as its most human moment.

The adaptations that followed, *Total Recall* (1990), *Minority Report* (2002), *A Scanner Darkly* (2006), *The Adjustment Bureau* (2011), the television series *The Man in the High Castle* (2015–19) and *Electric Dreams* (2017–18), and the films of Dickian cinema without Dick, among them *The Truman Show* (1998), *Dark City* (1998), *The Matrix* (1999), *eXistenZ* (1999), *Inception* (2010), and the series *Westworld* (2016–22), have overwhelmingly rendered the paranoid Dick: the twist, the reveal, the conspiracy, the fabricated world exposed. The reparative Dick, the toad, the pot, the flower, the embrace at the gas station, has proved nearly unfilmable, or at least unfilmed, with the honourable exception of Linklater's retention of the Author's

Note. The disparity is instructive. A cinema of spectacle privileges revelation, while repair is slow, repetitive, and unspectacular, the invisible labour that Ukeles's maintenance art set out to make visible. Dick's reparative imagination resists the medium that made him famous, which is one reason its recovery has fallen to reading.

CONCLUSION

The Pot-Healer's Wager



This dissertation began at the curb, with a dog's theology of garbage. It has traced five genealogies of Dick's thought, the Heraclitean and phenomenological, the Gnostic, Lurianic, and Origenist, the thermodynamic and informational, the Marxian, Benjaminian, and Baudrillardian, and the psychoanalytic, and it has read his fiction against them and against the cognate work of his contemporaries and successors. Its argument has been that the materials of Dick's fiction are paranoid-schizoid while its direction is reparative; that its decisive climaxes are acts of care toward degraded, counterfeit, or broken things; that its characteristic hero is the repairman; and that its implicit metaphysics is a reparative ontology in which the real is neither given, nor lost, nor elsewhere, but mended, and in which the seam is the locus of value.

Dick's two questions receive their answers only through the third. What is real? What is maintained, and what persists when belief is withdrawn persists because care has not been (Proposition III). What is human? The practice of repair, whatever the substrate that performs it (Proposition VII). What is worth repairing? The answer the fiction gives, with remarkable consistency, is the one dictated by the kenotic gradient: what the world has discarded.

Pascal's wager (*Pensées*, 1670) proposed that since reason cannot decide whether God exists, one should wager that God does, because the expected gain is infinite and the stake finite. Dick's fiction proposes a different wager, not on the reality of God but on the worth of repair. It can be stated in the idiom of its last great image: even if the toad is fake, order the flies. The questions that Dick's novels leave permanently open are whether the world is real, whether the object is authentic, whether the divine is present, and whether the other has an inner life. Under that uncertainty the pot-healer wagers on repair. If the thing is real, repair honours it. If it is fake, repair confers on it the only reality that finally matters, the reality of being cared for (Propositions IV and V). The stake is effort, and effort is

what the repairman has. The wager is the practical correlate of reparative ontology, and its effect is to convert undecidability from a cause of paranoia into an occasion of care. Joe Fernwright's ugly pot is the wager made visible.

The study has limitations that its method obliges it to name. The first concerns psychobiography. The Kleinian frame risks reducing the fiction to the author's infancy; it has been used here as a structural heuristic, and the resonance between the starving twins and the oral persecutors of the fiction remains suggestive rather than demonstrative. The second concerns the transposition of clinical theory to texts. Klein described infants and analysands, not novels, and Sedgwick's transposition is a precedent, not a warrant; the positions invoked here are figures of reading. The third concerns the *Exegesis*. The published selection amounts to roughly a tenth of the manuscript, and any account of the late theology depends on editorial choices that the full archive might revise; the Lurianic reading proposed in Chapter 8 in particular awaits testing against the whole. The fourth concerns kintsugi, whose appropriation as a figure carries the risks acknowledged in Chapter 9. The fifth concerns domestication. A reparative reading must not tame Dick's horror. The claws of "Second Variety," the teeth of Palmer Eldritch, and the Empire that never ended are real presences in the texts, and the argument would fail if it forgot them. The sixth concerns selection. The realist novels Dick wrote in the 1950s, several of them set among small shops and repair businesses in the California of his youth, have been under-examined here, and they may prove to be the ground from which his repairman grew.

Four lines of further research follow. The first is the systematic study of the *Exegesis* as a whole, for which the collaborative and computational methods of the digital humanities are now well suited, and for which community annotation projects have already begun to lay foundations. The second is a comparative study of Dick and Lem as the two founding theologians of simulation, the one writing from the creature's need, the other from the creator's burden. The third is a genealogy of the repairman across speculative fiction, from Le Guin and Butler to Chiang and beyond, which would bring science-fiction studies into sustained conversation with the ethics of care. The fourth is the integration of literary study into the broader turn toward maintenance in the humanities and social sciences, represented by Jackson's broken world thinking and by Andrew Russell and Lee Vinsel's work on the maintainers who sustain technological societies (Russell and Vinsel 2016; 2020), a turn that Ukeles anticipated in 1969 and that Dick's fiction anticipated throughout the same decade.

In 1982 Dick's ashes were carried to Fort Morgan, Colorado, and interred beside his sister Jane, beneath the stone that had carried his name since 1929. For fifty-three years a place had been kept on it for a surviving twin, a vessel held open for someone. It is a fitting emblem for an oeuvre in which the dead are kept, the broken are mended, and the discarded are carried home.

The dog of "Roog" was right about one thing. The collectors do carry off the family's offerings every week. He was wrong about what the offerings were. They were not the family's treasures but what the family had ceased to maintain. Dick spent the rest of his life writing the answer to his first published story, and the answer is that the offerings become treasures again when someone refuses to let them go. The real is what someone has refused to throw away.

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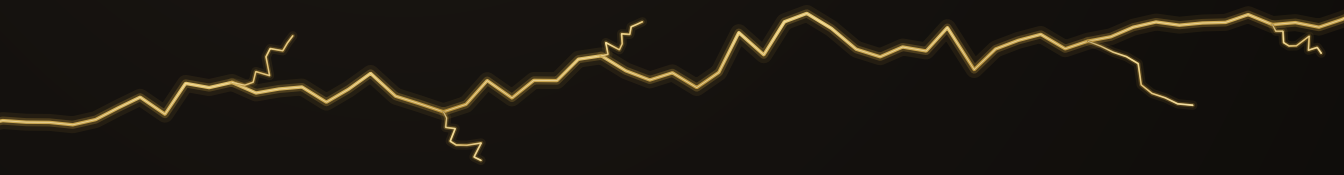
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KEYWORDS

Philip K. Dick · reparative ontology · the gilded seam · kintsugi · wu · paranoid reading · reparative reading · Eve Kosofsky Sedgwick · Melanie Klein · depressive position · manic reparation · idios kosmos · koinos kosmos · existential psychiatry · simulacrum · hyperreality · historicity · Gnosticism · reparative Gnosticism · Lurianic Kabbalah · tikkun · apokatastasis · kenosis · kenotic gradient · trash stratum · kipple · entropy · negentropy · living information · pharmakon · android · empathy · Voigt-Kampff test · anthropological machine · ethics of care · maintenance · repair studies · sinthome · Exegesis · VALIS · damaged God · science fiction studies · posthumanism · simulation hypothesis · machine minds · ecological restoration · Anthropocene



The real is what someone has refused to throw away.